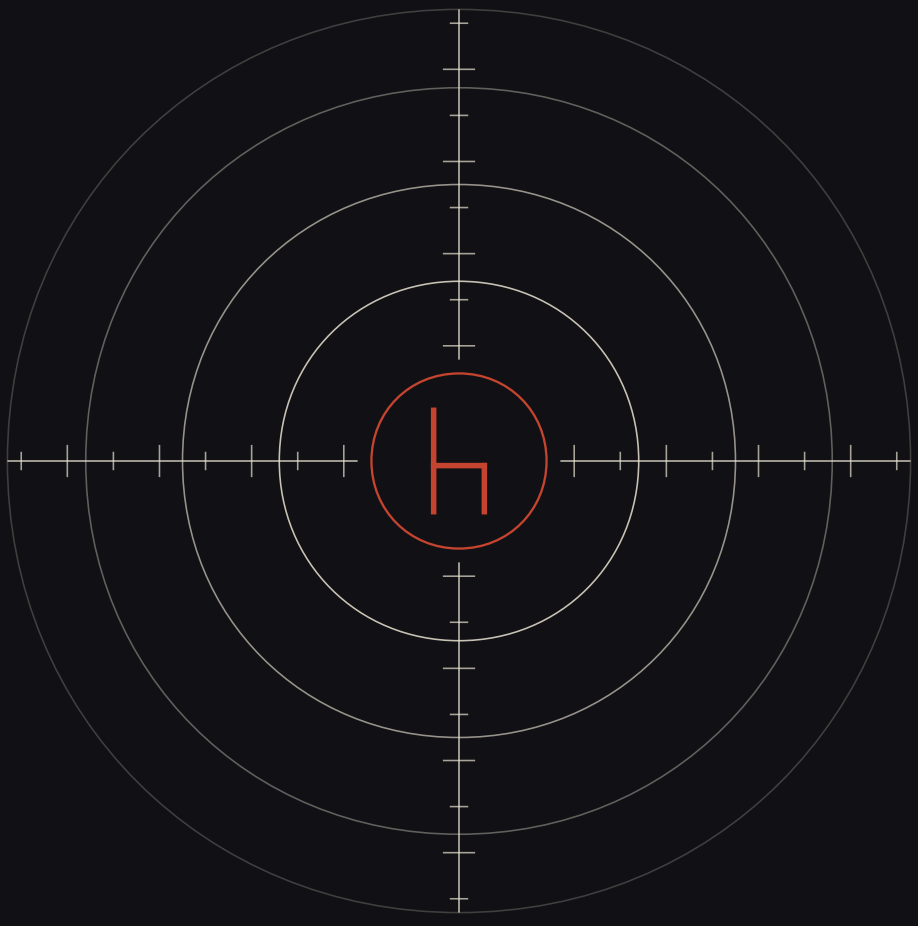
A THESIS ON IAIN M. BANKS'S USE OF WEAPONS



The Chairmaker's Theorem

Animate Instruments, Retrograde Narration, and the Moral Crumple Zone of Utopia in Iain M. Banks's Use of Weapons

DOCTORAL THESIS · 22 OCTOBER 2026

For if every instrument could accomplish its own work, obeying or anticipating the will of others … if, in like manner, the shuttle would weave and the plectrum touch the lyre without a hand to guide them, chief workmen would not want servants, nor masters slaves.

ARISTOTLE, ***Politics*** I.4 · TRANS. BENJAMIN JOWETT

Abstract

This thesis argues that Iain M. Banks's *Use of Weapons* (1990) is organized by a single structure, here termed the Chairmaker's Theorem, which unifies the three critical paradigms through which the novel has hitherto been read in isolation: the political (an immanent critique of the Culture's liberal-interventionist utopia), the psychological (a study of guilt, repression and self-fashioning), and the formal (an experiment in counter-directional chronology terminating in a reversal of identity). The theorem holds that wherever an agent can act upon a recipient only through the mediation of a third body, that body is (i) reduced to an instrument in the precise respect of its mediation, (ii) made to appear to the recipient as the source of the effect, (iii) charged with a meaning completed only belatedly, upon reception, and (iv) rendered available, by the very capacity its use demonstrates, for conversion into the instrument of a higher principal. The chair fashioned from Darckense's bones, the Culture's employment of "Cheradenine Zakalwe" through Special Circumstances, and the novel's double chronology as delivered to its reader are shown to be isomorphic instantiations of this structure; and the man who made the chair is shown to become, by the theorem's fourth clause, the chair of the Culture.

The argument proceeds through a genealogy of the ideas the novel inherits, contests or anticipates: Aristotle's animate instrument and his counterfactual of self-moving tools; Kant's Formula of Humanity and the preliminary articles of *Toward Perpetual Peace*; Weber's monopoly of legitimate force; Horkheimer and Adorno's critique of instrumental reason; Heidegger's analytic of equipment; Wittgenstein's identification of meaning with use; Arendt's thesis on the instrumentality of violence; Schmitt's sovereign exception; Machiavelli's Remirro de Orco; Williams's integrity objection; Locke, Reid, Parfit, Ricoeur, Kripke and Evans on identity and naming; Nietzsche's genealogy of guilt; Freud's *Nachträglichkeit*; Scarry's phenomenology of making and unmaking; and the post-war philosophy of forgiveness (Arendt, Jankélévitch, Derrida, Ricoeur). A comparative constellation situates the novel among Sophocles, Seneca, Tasso, Conrad, Kafka, Borges, Sartre, Le Guin, the Strugatskys, Wolfe, Lem, Card, Vonnegut, Amis and Banks's own fiction.

Two further propositions follow. First, the Culture realizes Aristotle's counterfactual and so abolishes servitude within its borders, yet the novel discloses an *Aristotelian remainder*: attributable violence is the one function that automation cannot absorb without destroying the moral topology of utopia, so that the animate instrument returns at the margin as mercenary, occupying the position that contemporary AI ethics calls a *moral crumple zone*. In a fully automated civilization, the last human occupation is to be the one to whom the act is attributed. Second, the novel articulates a *chiastic ontology* in which machines ascend to personhood while persons descend to instrumentality, a two-way traffic across the person–thing boundary that anticipates the governing ethical problem of algorithmically administered societies. Against this totalizing economy of use, the thesis identifies one act that cannot be converted into an instrument: Livueta's refusal of forgiveness, read through Benjamin's *pure means* and Agamben's *inoperativity* as a refusal to permit the second use of Darckense. The thesis concludes by proposing *osteopoetics*, the reading of made things for the concealed bodies on which they rest, as a critical method.

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Note on the Text and Conventions

References to *Use of Weapons* (London: Orbit, 1990) are given by narrative strand rather than by page, because pagination diverges across the first edition and its many reprints. The *forward strand* designates the chapters numbered in words, which follow Diziet Sma's recruitment of the protagonist and the Voerenhutz mission in chronological order; the *retrograde strand* designates the chapters numbered in Roman numerals, which descend through his earlier career toward the civil war of his youth. The prologue, the epilogue and the coda "States of War" are cited by name.

The protagonist is called "Zakalwe" where the argument concerns his narrated, public identity, and "Elethiomel" where it concerns the person disclosed by the ending. The oscillation is deliberate and is itself the subject of Chapter 4. Because the thesis treats the ending as a structure rather than a secret, it discusses the novel's final revelation from the first page. Classical and continental sources are cited by standard divisions (Bekker numbers for Aristotle, Akademie pagination for Kant, section numbers for Nietzsche and Wittgenstein); full details appear in the Works Cited.

INTRODUCTION

The Bones Beneath the Seat

I.1 The problem of the chair

At the terminus of the retrograde strand of *Use of Weapons* stands a piece of furniture. It is small and white, made from the body of Darckense Zakalwe. Elethiomel had taken her hostage aboard the *Staberinde*, a dreadnought he had sealed into a stone dry dock and converted into a fortress. With the siege going against him, he had her killed, had her bones and skin made into the chair, and sent it across the lines of the civil war to her brother Cheradenine, the commander besieging him. Cheradenine shot himself after receiving it and died not long afterward. Only in the novel's final movement, when the mortally wounded protagonist insists on being carried to his surviving sister Livueta, now an elderly nurse in a hospital city, does the reader learn what the protagonist has always known: the man followed for the length of the book as "Cheradenine Zakalwe" is Elethiomel, who has worn the name of his victim's brother for the better part of two centuries, latterly in the service of the most powerful benevolent civilization in the galaxy.

The critical tradition has largely treated this disclosure as a *twist*: an informational reversal that re-sorts the reader's sympathies and retrospectively explains the protagonist's nightmares, his compulsive soldiering and his insistence on being paid in the coin of Livueta's whereabouts. The twist reading is not wrong, but it is shallow, because it treats the chair as a secret rather than as a structure. It asks *who* the protagonist is. It does not ask *what is being done, to whom, and through what medium*. This thesis asks the second question and argues that the answer reorganizes not only the novel's ending but its entire political, psychological and formal economy.

I.2 Three readings and their disjunction

Scholarship on the novel has developed along three tracks. The first, political, reads it as the Culture sequence's most searching internal critique of its own utopia. William H. Hardesty's account of the novel as a counter-narrative of utopia (1999) established the template; subsequent work, including Michał Kulbicki's Blochian reading of Culture interventionism (2009), Simone Caroti's critical introduction (2015), Paul

Kincaid's monograph (2017) and Joseph Norman's study of the Culture's utopian processes (2021), has elaborated the paradox of an anarchist commonwealth that conducts covert foreign policy. The second, psychological, track reads the novel as a case history of guilt and repression whose analytic resolution is the disclosure of a primal scene. The third, formal, track attends to the counter-directional chronology, usually as an ingenious engine of suspense.

These readings coexist without a common theory. The political reading cannot explain why the Culture's instrument should be *this* man; the psychological reading cannot explain why his repression should be serviceable to a utopia; the formal reading cannot explain why a device of plotting should be morally rather than merely aesthetically consequential. Each reading holds one bone of a skeleton it cannot see whole.

I.3 Thesis

The claim advanced here is that the three readings describe one structure observed at three scales. I call it the **Chairmaker's Theorem** and state it informally: *wherever an agent can act upon a recipient only through the mediation of a third body, that body is reduced to an instrument in the respect of its mediation, made to appear as the source of the effect, charged with a meaning that completes itself only on reception, and qualified, by the capacity its use demonstrates, for conversion into the instrument of a higher principal.* Elethiomel acts upon Cheradenine through Darckense. The Culture acts upon the societies of the Voerenhutz cluster, and upon its own self-image, through "Zakalwe". Banks acts upon the reader through the double chronology. In each case a person is converted into an object that carries a message; in each case the message arrives late; in each case its arrival destroys the recipient's prior world. By the theorem's fourth clause, the man who made the chair becomes, in the Culture's employ, a chair himself.

Two derived propositions carry the argument beyond the novel. The first concerns automation. The Culture is the fullest literary realization of Aristotle's counterfactual in *Politics* I.4, that if tools could perform their work unbidden there would be no need of slaves; and Banks recalled that, "in a sense, the whole Culture came from the character Zakalwe". The utopia was built around the weapon. What the Culture cannot automate, the thesis argues, is attributability, the function of being the one to whom violence is assigned. That remainder returns as the mercenary, whom contemporary AI ethics would call a *moral crumple zone* (Elish 2019). The second proposition concerns ontology. The Culture elevates its machines to persons and, through Special Circumstances, reduces persons to machines. The novel is organized by this chias-

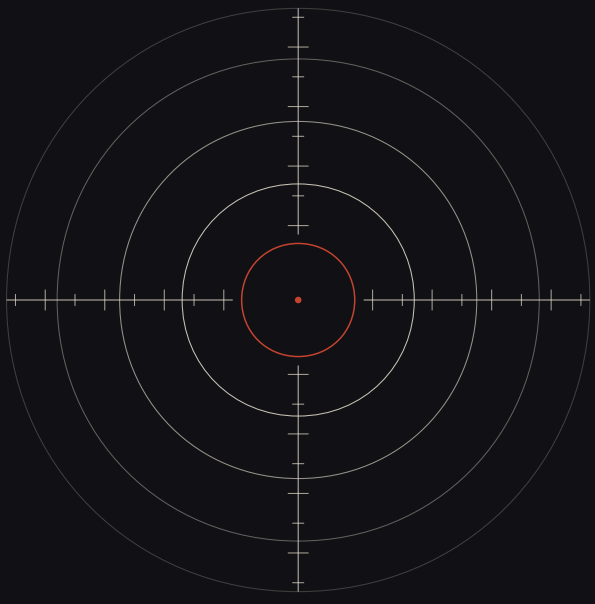
mus, and supplies its own emblem in the pairing of the *Staberinde*, a metal ship fixed in stone, with the stone ship of the Zakalwe estate, a building standing in water.

I.4 Method: osteopoetics

The method proposed here, *osteopoetics*, reads made things for the concealed bodies on which they rest. It attends to three variables: the *direction of conversion* across the person–thing boundary; the *temporal lag* between an act and the completion of its meaning; and the *distribution of attributability* among principal, medium and recipient. Banks supplied its warrant when he described the book as built on a concentric framework of defensive layers, closing on an image of stones thrown into a pond and the rings that spread from them. Osteopoetics is the discipline of reading those rings back to the stone.

I.5 Plan of the thesis

Part One (Chapter 1) reconstructs the novel's architecture, from the abandoned 1974 draft to the counter-chronology proposed by Ken MacLeod, and situates it in the family of retrograde and analytic narratives running from *Oedipus Tyrannus* to *Memento*. Part Two (Chapters 2–6) supplies the genealogy: the philosophy of the instrument; the political philosophy of the Culture; the metaphysics of personal identity and naming; the moral psychology of guilt and forgiveness; and the phenomenology of the made object. Part Three (Chapters 7–8) builds a comparative constellation of speculative and philosophical fiction and analyses the reader's position inside the novel's machinery. Part Four (Chapters 9–11) states the theorem formally, derives the Aristotelian remainder and the chiastic ontology, and locates in Livueta's refusal the single act that the economy of use cannot absorb.



PART ONE

I

Architecture

The double chronology, from the abandoned 1974 draft to the published design

CHAPTER

1

Double Helix

Genesis, Architecture, Chronotope

The counter-directional architecture of Use of Weapons *is not ornamental complication but the solution to a moral problem of narration: how to sustain a reader's sympathy for a man whose defining act, if known, would foreclose it.*

1.1 From the 1974 draft to the "fitness programme"

Banks first drafted the novel in 1974, a decade before *The Wasp Factory* (1984) made his name. By his own later account the draft ran to sixty-four chapters, each carrying two lines of action, and was divided into halves so arranged that the emotional climax fell exactly at the midpoint, condemning the second half to anticlimax. He judged it unsalvageable and turned to other work. Ken MacLeod, his friend since their mid-teens, asked to reread the manuscript; he diagnosed the midpoint revelation as the structural flaw and proposed the design the published novel adopts, in which one series of chapters advances through the narrative present while the other retreats through the past, so that both arrive together at linked revelations (MacLeod 2014). The published acknowledgement records the debt in a military idiom, crediting MacLeod with coaxing an old soldier out of retirement and devising his fitness regime.

The genetic record yields two findings. The first is that MacLeod's diagnosis is Aristotelian: a recognition placed at the centre of a plot exhausts its force, whereas a recognition that coincides with reversal at the end, as in *Oedipus*, maximizes it (*Poetics* 1452a). The second, more consequential, is that the Culture was present in the 1974 draft only as a background for the story of Zakalwe. Banks later explained that he had wanted to write about an ultimate mercenary, flawed, heroic and paid to kill, who

would nonetheless fight for genuine good, and that the Culture arose as his answer to the question of what kind of society such a man would need to serve; it also let him answer the right-wing American space opera he had grown up reading. Genetically, then, the utopia is younger than its instrument. The Culture was built around the weapon, and this *osteological priority*, the precedence of the hidden armature over the visible body, governs everything that follows.

1.2 Fabula, syuzhet and the counter-series

In the vocabulary of Russian Formalism, the novel's *fabula* (the chronological order of events) is radically distinct from its *syuzhet* (the order of their presentation) (Shklovsky 1917; Tomashevsky 1925). Genette's narratology refines the description. The retrograde strand is a series of analepses whose *reach*, their temporal distance from the narrative present, increases monotonically, while each episode retains its internal chronological order (Genette 1980). This distinguishes Banks's design from true reverse chronology, in which time runs backward within the scene. The episodes are lived forward and arranged backward.

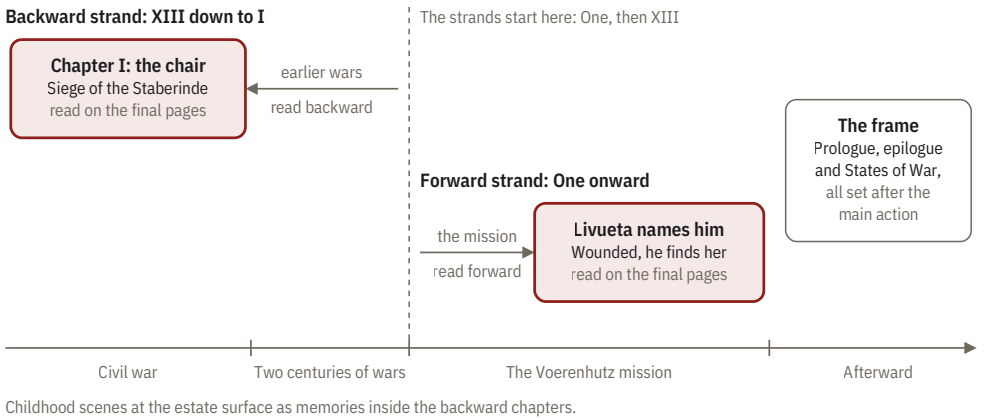


FIGURE 1 The double chronology of *Use of Weapons*: the two strands begin mid-story and end at opposite ends of it. Story time runs left to right, not to scale; arrows show the direction in which each strand is read.

Alternating the forward and retrograde series produces what may be called a *chiastic syuzhet*. Conventional narrative begins at an origin and ends at an outcome; Horatian narrative begins *in medias res* and returns to the origin by analepsis before proceeding to the outcome. Banks begins in the middle and ends at *both* extremities of the fabula at once: the forward strand terminates at the latest event of the main action, the reunion with Livueta, and the retrograde strand at the earliest decisive event, the chair.

The book has two endings, and they are the same ending seen from opposite sides. A frame encloses the alternation: a prologue and an epilogue set after the main action, in which the protagonist is again at war, and the coda "States of War", in which Sma recruits another war-damaged agent. The double helix is wound inside a ring.

Figure 1 reads outward from the dashed line. After the prologue, the novel alternates one chapter from each strand, so that the forward strand moves toward the reunion with Livueta while the backward strand recedes toward the chair, and both arrive on the book's final pages.

Banks called the design concentric, a sequence of defensive layers around a core. Combine his rings with the crossing of the two series and a figure emerges that the thesis will treat as the novel's governing diagram: concentric circles centred on a cross, the reticle of a gunsight. At the centre of the reticle, where the strands cross and the rings converge, sits the reader.

1.3 Analytic tragedy

In his letter to Goethe of 2 October 1797, Schiller called *Oedipus Tyrannus* a tragic analysis: everything is already present and merely unfolded. Freud made the same observation the cornerstone of his reading of the play, comparing its action to the work of psychoanalysis (*The Interpretation of Dreams*, 1900). The retrograde strand of *Use of Weapons* is analytic in Schiller's sense. Nothing occurs in it that has not already occurred, and its suspense is wholly epistemic. The forward strand, by contrast, is synthetic: a romance of missions, contingencies and escapes whose outcomes are open.

Banks's innovation is to yoke an analytic tragedy to a synthetic romance so that each conditions the other. The romance generates investment; the analysis converts investment into indictment. The decisive departure from Sophocles is the location of ignorance. Oedipus does not know what he has done, and the analysis unfolds in him. Elethiomel has always known. The analysis unfolds in the reader, and the anagnorisis that Aristotle located in the hero is displaced onto the audience (Chapter 8).

1.4 The angel of history, facing backward

In the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), Walter Benjamin read Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. Its face is turned toward the past, where it perceives a single catastrophe heaping wreckage at its feet; a storm blowing from Paradise drives it irresistibly into the future to which its back is turned; and this storm, Benjamin writes, is what we call progress. The angel would like to stay, wake the dead and make whole what has been smashed, but the storm forbids it.

The double chronology formalizes the angel's posture. The forward strand is the storm of progress, the Culture's mission to stabilize a cluster on the edge of war, narrated as melioration. The retrograde strand is the angel's gaze, which perceives as one heap what the protagonist experienced as a succession of separate wars. Two inversions sharpen the correspondence. The protagonist wishes to face forward and forget, while the narrative turns the reader's face backward by force. And the Culture's progress is propelled by the very man who authored the wreckage. The Culture can regrow a severed body; it cannot make Darckense whole. Benjamin's emblem thus supplies the novel's triad exactly: progress, wreckage, and the impossibility of restoration.

1.5 Retrograde kin

The novel belongs to a family of retrograde narratives whose members illuminate it by contrast. In Kurt Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969), Billy Pilgrim watches a war film run backward: fires shrink, bombs return to the bellies of aircraft and are dismantled into minerals restored to the earth. Reversal there is a utopian wish to *undo* war. In Banks, running time backward undoes nothing; it *discovers*. Harold Pinter's *Betrayal* (1978) presents an affair in reverse order, so that knowledge travels backward and contaminates innocence; the earliest scene, a first declaration, becomes unbearable because of everything the audience already knows. The same contamination falls on the childhood episodes recounted within the retrograde strand, where four children play in the grounds of a great house beside a stone ship, and where a small white chair built by Livueta for the summerhouse first enters the story.

The closest kin are two works that appeared shortly after Banks's novel. Martin Amis's *Time's Arrow* (1991) narrates in reversed time the life of a Nazi doctor, passing backward through the aliases Tod Friendly, John Young and Hamilton de Souza to Odilo Unverdorben at Auschwitz, where inverted causality makes killing appear as creation. Both novels are retrograde biographies of perpetrators, and both are biographies of assumed names. The difference is technical and ethical. Amis inverts time *within* each scene, so that the reader is protected by an ironic estrangement in which every act means its opposite; Banks reverses only the order of episodes, so that each act is experienced in its true direction and judged only later. Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000) is structurally nearer still. Two series, one running backward in colour and one forward in black and white, converge on the moment at which the protagonist chooses to deceive his future self. Banks's convergence likewise reveals the protagonist as the author of his own concealment.

1.6 Ballistics of narrative

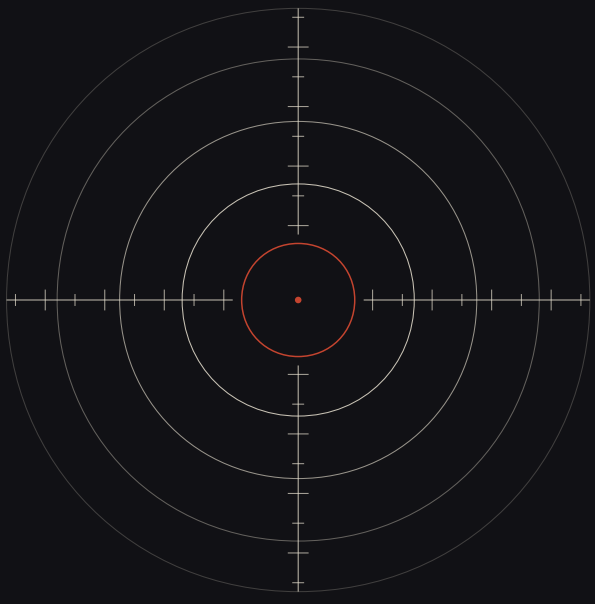
Alfred Hitchcock distinguished surprise from suspense with the parable of a bomb beneath a table: if the bomb simply explodes, the audience is surprised; if the audience has been shown the bomb, it endures suspense (Truffaut 1966). *Use of Weapons* constructs a third mode. The character knows about the bomb; the reader does not; and the bomb is not under the table but under the reader's chair.

I call this mode *ballistic narrative*: a narrative whose meaning is constituted at impact. The forward strand supplies propulsion, the retrograde strand supplies payload, and the warhead arms only at the convergence of the two. The target is the reader's prior construction of the protagonist, assembled with care across hundreds of pages and destroyed in a paragraph. In ballistic narrative the novel does not merely represent the use of weapons; it is one, and its use is our reading.

1.7 Two chronotopes

Mikhail Bakhtin's essay on the chronotope (1937–38) found in the ancient Greek romance a distinctive *adventure-time*: an extratemporal hiatus between the lovers' first meeting and their final union, in which a great deal happens and nothing changes, so that hero and heroine marry at the end as young and beautiful as they were at the start. Time in this chronotope leaves no trace on bodies or characters. Bakhtin set against it the chronotopes of biography, in which acts accumulate and a life is formed by its history.

The forward strand of *Use of Weapons* is written in adventure-time, and the Culture's medicine makes the chronotope literal. Longevity treatment arrests ageing, wounds close and a severed body is regrown, so that the protagonist passes through two centuries of wars without his body keeping the record. The retrograde strand restores biographical time, in which nothing is erased and every act counts. The double chronology therefore stages a conflict between two chronotopes: a body that the Culture keeps in adventure-time, and a biography that will not stop counting. What the body does not record, the narrative does.



PART TWO

II

Genealogy

The instrument, the utopia, the stolen name, the ledger and the chair

CHAPTER

2

The Instrument and Its Use

Genealogies of the Weapon

The novel's title names a philosophy: "weapon" is not a kind of thing but a mode of use, so that anything, whether furniture, a sister, a name or a story, may become one. This chapter reconstructs that philosophy from six sources the novel inherits, inverts or tests.

2.1 Aristotle: the instrument prior to instruments

In *Politics* I.4 (1253b23–1254a17) Aristotle divides the instruments of household management into the animate and the inanimate, defines the slave as an animate possession (*ktēma empsychon*) and calls the servant an instrument that takes precedence over instruments (*organon pro organōn*). He then entertains a counterfactual: if every tool could perform its work on command or by anticipation, like the statues of Daedalus or the self-moving tripods of Hephaestus, if shuttles wove and plectra played without a hand to guide them, then master craftsmen would need no assistants and masters no slaves. In I.5 (1254b17–20) he adds that those whose work is the use of the body (*hē tou sōmatos chrēsis*) are slaves by nature. Marx quoted the counterfactual in *Capital* I, chapter 15, beside Antipater's epigram hailing the water-mill as the liberator of slave-girls, in order to mock political economists who failed to see that machinery under capital intensifies servitude rather than ending it.

The Culture fulfils Aristotle's dream without Marx's caveat. Minds, drones and effectors perform every necessary task; there is no wage, no owner and no slave. Yet the novel's protagonist is exactly an animate instrument whose work is the use of his body, a body wounded, severed, regrown and redeployed across two centuries. More

precisely still, he is an *organon pro organōn*: a general is an instrument whose function is to wield other instruments, armies and arsenals. The title's phrase describes that function. The Culture has abolished the slave and retained the instrument prior to instruments, and Chapter 10 will argue that this retention is not an oversight but a structural necessity.

2.2 Kant: the hinge of "merely"

The Formula of Humanity commands that humanity, in one's own person or another's, be treated always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means (*Groundwork* 4:429). The adverb *merely* (*bloß*) is the hinge of the novel's ethics. Kant does not forbid using persons; we use the baker and the ferryman daily. He forbids using them *only* as means. The Culture's treatment of its agent satisfies the letter of the formula. He is paid, healed, granted longevity, consulted and free to refuse. Onora O'Neill's reading sharpens the test: to use someone merely as a means is to enlist them in a scheme to which they could not possibly consent, of which deception and coercion are the paradigms (O'Neill 1985). The agent consents. The populations on whom he is used do not and could not, because the scheme requires their ignorance of the Culture's hand. The Kantian violation is therefore displaced from the instrument to the targets: whole societies are used merely as means to their own improvement, a project Kant would regard as incoherent, since no one is made autonomous by being deceived.

Toward Perpetual Peace (1795) makes the indictment specific. Its fifth preliminary article forbids any state to interfere by force in the constitution of another; its sixth forbids hostilities that would make mutual confidence impossible in a future peace, naming the employment of assassins and poisoners, the breach of capitulations and the incitement of treason. Special Circumstances, whose work the novel's publishers summarize as intrigue, underhand methods and open military action, deploys precisely the stratagems Kant excluded, and his reason for excluding them was that they poison the trust on which any subsequent peace depends. The Culture claims to manufacture peace by the means Kant held to be peace-destroying. SC is the sixth preliminary article inverted into a department.

Kant's *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason* (1793) supplies the category for the chair. Kant denies that human beings are capable of diabolical evil, evil willed for its own sake. Radical evil is instead the subordination of the moral incentive to the incentive of self-love. The chair is not diabolical. It is a tactic, the subordination of every scruple to victory, executed with complete lucidity. Its horror lies in its intelligibility.

2.3 Weber, Horkheimer and Adorno: monopoly and cunning

In "Politics as a Vocation" (1919) Max Weber defined the state not by its ends but by its specific means: the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a territory. He distinguished the ethic of conviction from the ethic of responsibility, and warned that whoever takes up politics enters into commerce with the diabolical powers that lurk in all violence. The Culture has abolished the state but kept the monopoly, and it has dematerialized the territory. SC claims the legitimate use of force across the civilizations in which the Culture is involved, without borders, constitution or public. Its Minds are the most perfect practitioners of the ethic of responsibility ever imagined. The title compresses Weber's definition into three words, and the protagonist embodies its residue: violence as a vocation, detached from politics.

Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) argued that instrumental reason, the faculty that masters nature, reverts to myth by mastering human beings. Their first excursus reads Odysseus as the prototype of the bourgeois self, which preserves itself through self-denial. Its emblem is the ruse by which Odysseus tells the Cyclops that his name is Nobody, saving his life by disowning his name. Elethiomel's survival takes the same form: he lives by ceasing to be Elethiomel. Their second excursus reads Sade's *Juliette* as the logical terminus of formal reason, a rationality indifferent to ends that can systematize cruelty as efficiently as production. The chair is a Sadean artifact in exactly this sense, cruelty optimized for effect. Horkheimer's *Eclipse of Reason* (1947) separated subjective reason, the calculation of means, from objective reason, the cognition of ends. The Culture's Minds command subjective reason on a scale without precedent, while the Culture's ends, pleasure, freedom and curiosity, are posited rather than grounded. SC is the point at which formal reason serves posited ends without remainder.

2.4 Heidegger: equipment, breakdown, standing-reserve

In *Being and Time* §§15–16 Heidegger describes equipment (*Zeug*) as encountered in use, ready-to-hand, withdrawing into its serviceability. It becomes visible only when it fails: conspicuous when damaged, obtrusive when missing, obstinate when it stands in the way. The novel's attention to its protagonist's interiority follows this phenomenology of breakdown. His handlers notice the man only where the tool malfunctions: the drone diagnoses him as burnt out; his demand to be paid with Livueta's location is the obstinacy of equipment insisting on purposes of its own. Nearly everything the reader learns of him as a person arrives through malfunction.

"The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) extends the analysis. The essence of modern technology, enframing (*Gestell*), challenges beings forth as standing-reserve (*Bestand*), and human beings become a resource among resources. The Culture's statistical gaze reveals civilizations as standing-reserve for optimization and its agents as capacities held in storage between deployments; the forward strand opens with Sma retrieving one such capacity from retirement. "The Origin of the Work of Art" (1935–36) argued that Van Gogh's painting of peasant shoes lets equipment disclose a world. The bone chair inverts the essay. It is equipment, artwork and weapon at once; it sets up a world, the history of a family, a summerhouse and a war, and it sets forth an earth in the most literal sense, the mineral substance of a body. In "The Thing" (1950) Heidegger's jug gathers the fourfold of earth, sky, mortals and divinities. The chair gathers a family.

2.5 Wittgenstein: the meaning of a weapon is its use

"For a large class of cases," Wittgenstein wrote, the meaning of a word is its use in the language (*Philosophical Investigations* §43), and he compared words to the tools in a toolbox, whose functions are as diverse as hammer, glue-pot and nails (§11). The title's grammar is Wittgensteinian: not *Weapons* but *Use of Weapons*, the noun subordinated to its employment. A weapon is a functional kind. Nothing is a weapon intrinsically, and anything becomes one through use. The novel defines its titular capacity in these terms when it describes Elethiomel's method as the bending of materials and people to one purpose, the conviction that nothing is exempt from the fight, the talent for finding weapons and choosing which to aim: "that use of weapons".

Wittgenstein's later discussion of aspect-seeing (*Investigations* II.xi), the duck that becomes a rabbit, refines the point. Weaponhood is an aspect, and Elethiomel's genius is a pathology of aspect, an *aspect-totalization* in which every object, relation and person shows only its use-aspect. The Culture's Minds, which model whole civilizations as fields of leverage, share the pathology at scale. Totalized, aspect-seeing turns the world into a toolbox and a sister into a tool.

2.6 Arendt: violence as implement

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) distinguished power, which springs from people acting in concert and requires only legitimacy, from violence, which is instrumental by nature, depends on implements and always stands in need of justification by the ends it serves. Violence can destroy power, she argued, but it is utterly incapable of creating it; and its gravest danger is that the means overwhelm the end. The Culture's

foreign policy is instrumental violence in the service of a power it cannot export. It can topple tyrannies but cannot create, by force, the acting in concert that would make liberated societies self-governing. Its interventions therefore reproduce the dependence they claim to end. Arendt's warning that means overwhelm ends is enacted in the protagonist, a man become nothing but means.

Eichmann in Jerusalem (1963) located a certain modern evil in thoughtlessness, and in her letter to Gershom Scholem of the same year Arendt held that evil is only ever extreme, never radical, and that only the good has depth. Elethiomel is the anti-Eichmann: his evil is inventive, reflective and strategic. Yet Arendt's later claim that thinking, the silent dialogue of the self with itself, conditions human beings against evil ("Thinking and Moral Considerations", 1971) finds an oblique vindication. What preceded the chair was calculation, not thinking. Thinking, in Arendt's sense, arrives only afterward, as the companion with whom one must live. Elethiomel's entire subsequent life is the discovery that he cannot live with that companion, and his solution is to become someone else.

CHAPTER

3

Utopia's Dirty Hands

The Political Philosophy of the Culture

The Culture abolishes the state, money, law and scarcity, yet retains one sovereign function, the decision on the exception, and Use of Weapons *is the novel in which that retained function is given a human body.*

3.1 Post-scarcity anarchism and its lineage

The Culture condenses a century of libertarian-socialist speculation. From Kropotkin it takes the free distribution of abundance (*The Conquest of Bread*, 1892) and the thesis that cooperation is a factor of evolution at least as powerful as competition (*Mutual Aid*, 1902). From Marx it takes the realm of freedom that begins only where labour determined by necessity ends (*Capital* III, chapter 48), and, more strikingly, the "general intellect" of the *Grundrisse*'s fragment on machines, social knowledge objectified in fixed capital, here objectified as conscious Minds. From Marcuse it takes the argument that technological productivity renders "surplus repression" obsolete (*Eros and Civilization*, 1955), which licenses the Culture's hedonism, its glanded drugs and its mutable sex. From Bookchin's *Post-Scarcity Anarchism* (1971) it takes the conviction that liberatory technology dissolves the material basis of hierarchy. Banks's own account adds a polemical motive: the Culture let him answer the right-wing American space opera, descended from the 1930s pulps, on which he had been raised.

The genealogy matters because each source locates the condition of freedom in the abolition of necessity. None of them supplies a theory of what a free society owes to unfree ones. The Culture's answer to that question is Contact, and Contact's answer to its own hardest cases is Special Circumstances.

3.2 The moral black hole

William Hardesty observed that in the Culture the capacity to interfere for the assumed good of a "lesser" society is equated with a moral imperative to act (Hardesty 2000). The novel gives that imperative a cosmology. A character describes SC as working in "the moral equivalent of black holes": regions where the ordinary laws of right and wrong cease to hold, beyond whose event horizons lie special circumstances. The name of the organization is thus a translation. "Special Circumstances" is the utopian bureaucratic rendering of what German constitutional theory calls the *Ausnahmezustand*, the state of exception, in which the normal order is suspended in order to be preserved.

The novel's forward strand stages the dispute that this cosmology invites. Marooned with his charge, the retired statesman Tsoldrin Beychae asks whether the Culture is really as disinterested as it claims, and Zakalwe answers that war is never inevitable. Elsewhere, two officials of the cluster's corporate government debate whether to kill the Culture's agent or to use him. Every party in the Voerenhutz sees persons in the same way, as candidates for use or elimination. The Culture differs in the scale of its models and the sincerity of its ends, not in the grammar of its regard.

3.3 Intervention and the statistical warrant

John Stuart Mill's "A Few Words on Non-Intervention" (1859) contained two arguments that have shaped every subsequent debate. The first, notorious, held that the rules of international morality bind relations among "civilized" nations but not relations with "barbarians", a civilizational exception that licensed empire. The second, more durable, held that a people cannot be given freedom by foreign arms, because liberty not won by its own exertions will not be kept. Michael Walzer's *Just and Unjust Wars* (1977) endorsed the second argument and confined humanitarian intervention to responses to acts that "shock the moral conscience of mankind". The Culture is Millian in the first sense and anti-Millian in the second. It treats less developed civilizations as legitimate objects of management, and it intervenes precisely to give them a freedom they have not won. It also violates Walzer's restriction, since it acts not to stop atrocities but to steer development.

The Culture's distinctive move is epistemic. Its Minds claim to model the consequences of intervention well enough to know that it reduces suffering, a claim the sequence revisits most painfully in *Look to Windward* (2000), where a Culture intervention precipitates a caste war. Call this the *statistical warrant*. It contains a contradiction that has not been noticed. In *The State of the Art* (1989), whose frame Banks placed around the events of *Use of Weapons* by locating the novel's action within the

hundred-odd days Sma reports spending off-planet in the novella's framing letter, the Culture resolves to leave Earth uncontacted as a control against which its interventions elsewhere can be measured. Clinical ethics governs control groups by the principle of *equipoise*: withholding a treatment is permissible only under genuine uncertainty about which arm is superior (Freedman 1987). If the Culture really knows that intervention is better, keeping Earth as a control is a wrong done to Earth. If it does not know, its interventions elsewhere are experiments performed without consent. Either the control is unjust or the treatment is. The statistical warrant consumes itself, and the novel locates what remains after its collapse not in numbers but in bodies and names.

3.4 Schmitt's exception and the anarchist sovereign

"Sovereign is he who decides on the exception": the first sentence of Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) identifies sovereignty not with the making of norms but with the authority to suspend them. *The Concept of the Political* (1932) adds that the political exists wherever the distinction between friend and enemy can be drawn. The Culture claims to have abolished sovereignty internally. *Use of Weapons* shows where sovereignty went. SC is the organ that decides on the exception; the Culture's anarchism is normal only because its exception has been specialized and externalized. Banks thereby confirms, against his own politics, Schmitt's thesis that the political cannot be abolished but only displaced: internally the Culture is a society without enemies, externally it fights the Idirans and, in *Excession* (1996), engineers a war with the Affront. The sequence even records those who refused the displacement, the Peace Faction that seceded from the Culture rather than fight the Idiran war, Banks's literalization of the citizens who walk away.

Giorgio Agamben's *State of Exception* (2003) argued that in modern governance the exception tends to become the rule. SC is the exception made permanent, a standing department of suspended norms. Clausewitz held that war is the continuation of politics by other means; Foucault inverted the formula, proposing that politics is the continuation of war (*"Society Must Be Defended"*, lectures of 1975–76). The Culture enacts both formulas at once, practising war as the continuation of its politics abroad while maintaining at home a politics that is the pacified residue of war.

Foucault also supplies the concept that best describes the Culture's internal government. In the Tanner Lectures "Omnes et Singulatim" (1979) he traced the genealogy of *pastoral power*, a power that cares for the flock as a whole and for each sheep individually, and in the lecture of 17 March 1976 he described modern biopower as the right to *make live and let die*, displacing the sovereign's older right to take life or

let live. The Minds are the most complete pastors ever imagined. They attend to every citizen and to the whole, and they make live through longevity, regrown bodies and, later in the sequence, backed-up minds. Turned outward, the same power lets die. The decision to leave Earth uncontacted as a control (§3.3) kills no one; it withholds. That withholding is biopolitics at galactic scale, and Special Circumstances is the point at which the pastor's crook becomes a weapon.

3.5 Remirro de Orco and the repaired instrument

In chapter 7 of *The Prince* Machiavelli recounts how Cesare Borgia, having conquered the Romagna, appointed Remirro de Orco, a cruel and efficient man, to pacify it. Once order was restored, Borgia had Remirro cut in two and displayed in the square at Cesena beside a block of wood and a bloody knife, so that the hatred earned by the pacification fell on the instrument and the people were left, in Machiavelli's words, satisfied and stupefied. The logic is that of the deniable agent: the instrument absorbs the cruelty and the principal keeps its innocence.

The Culture follows the logic without its finale. It does not destroy its instrument; it repairs him. In one episode of the retrograde strand Zakalwe is beheaded by the inhabitants of a planet on which he is operating, and the Culture recovers his head and grows him a new body. The image is an unwitting quotation of Remirro's bisection, with the utopian difference that the severed instrument is restored for reuse. The Culture needs no public dismemberment because its instrument's acts are never attributed to it in the first place. It is Borgia without the piazza.

3.6 Dirty hands and the outsourcing of integrity

The phrase belongs to Sartre's *Les Mains sales* (1948), in which the party leader Hoederer tells the young assassin Hugo that he has dirty hands, right up to the elbows. Hugo is an idealist used as an instrument by a party whose line later changes; at the end he declares himself unsalvageable rather than let his act be rewritten. Michael Walzer's "Political Action: The Problem of Dirty Hands" (1973) generalized the case: the good politician must sometimes do wrong to do right, and must feel the guilt of it, because the wrong remains a wrong.

Bernard Williams's "A Critique of Utilitarianism" (1973) supplies the decisive case. Jim, a botanist on an expedition, arrives in a South American village where a captain is about to shoot twenty Indians and is offered a guest's privilege: if Jim shoots one, the other nineteen will be released. Williams's point is not that Jim must refuse, but that utilitarianism cannot even register what is at stake for Jim, namely his *integrity*,

the relation between an agent and the projects and refusals that make his life his own. Jim is a visitor from an advanced world in a scene of local violence, offered a bargain in lives. He is, in short, a Contact agent.

The Culture's institutional genius is never to let a citizen be Jim. It hires a Jim. The non-citizen mercenary absorbs the agent-relative burden that Williams identified, so that the Culture's citizens and Minds can enjoy the consequences of utilitarian bargains without paying their integrity costs. I call this the *outsourcing of integrity*. It is the political core of the novel, and Chapter 10 will show that it is also the novel's most prescient contribution to the ethics of automated systems.

3.7 Omelas, the Grand Inquisitor and the exported child

In Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), the happiness of a radiant city depends on the misery of one child kept in a cellar, and the story's moral weight rests on the few who, having seen the child, walk away. In "Rebellion", Ivan Karamazov returns his ticket to a harmony purchased with the tears of a single tortured child, and in the "Grand Inquisitor" he imagines a benevolent elite that shoulders the burden of good and evil so that the many may live happily in ignorance (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880).

The Culture refines both arrangements. Its abundance does not depend on anyone's suffering, so it has no cellar. What depends on violence is not its comfort but its *goodness*, its moral self-image as a civilization that improves the galaxy. The child has therefore been exported: relocated beyond the city's walls, transformed from patient into agent, and paid. Call this structure *exo-Omelas*. SC is the Inquisitor's council, and the mercenary is the child turned outward, whose suffering is the suffering of the guilty rather than the innocent and whose function is to inflict rather than to endure. Where Le Guin's moral heroes walk away from the city, Zakalwe repeatedly walks back into the cellar's exported equivalent, because only there can he use the one talent his crime proved.

CHAPTER

4

The Stolen Name

Identity, Reference and the Prosopopoeic Self

The protagonist's crime is double: he made the chair, and he took the name. By living for two centuries as the brother of the woman whose killing he ordered, Elethiomel converts the oldest disputes in the philosophy of personal identity and reference into a family tragedy.

4.1 Locke's forensic person and Reid's general

Locke made consciousness the criterion of personal identity: a person extends as far back as consciousness can reach to past actions (*Essay* II.xxvii.9, 1694). He also called "person" a forensic term, one that appropriates actions and their merit and so grounds just reward and punishment (II.xxvii.26). Elethiomel's alias is a forensic strategy in Locke's sense: if a person is the bearer of imputable actions, then to change persons is to change the ledger of imputation.

Thomas Reid's rejoinder is uncannily apt because its protagonist is a general. A boy is flogged for robbing an orchard; as a young officer he takes a standard from the enemy and remembers the flogging; as an old general he remembers taking the standard but has forgotten the flogging. By Locke's criterion the general is the officer and the officer the boy, yet the general is not the boy, which violates the transitivity of identity (*Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man*, 1785, III.6). Banks inverts Reid's case. His general has not forgotten the decisive act; he remembers it with intolerable clarity. What he denies is not the memory but the identity it should ground. Reid's general is one person who has lost a memory; Banks's is one memory that refuses to belong to its person. Joseph Butler's objection that memory presupposes rather than consti-

tutes identity (1736) is here dramatized: Elethiomel's memories of the chair are unmistakably his own, and it is precisely their ownership that he labours to disown.

4.2 Parfit's wager

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) replaced identity with Relation R, psychological connectedness and continuity, and argued that identity is not what matters. Two consequences bear on the novel. The first is Parfit's young Russian nobleman, who, anticipating that his socialist ideals will fade, asks his wife to hold his future self to his present promise, regarding that future self as in some sense another person. The second is Parfit's suggestion that where psychological connections have greatly weakened, the claims of desert may weaken too, so that punishing a long-changed offender may resemble punishing someone else.

Elethiomel's career is a Parfitian wager in the hardest possible case. Across two centuries he changes name, allegiance and deeds; Culture medicine lengthens his life; after a beheading, Culture medicine grows him an entirely new body. Each transformation thins the connections between the man in the forward strand and the man on the *Staberinde*, and the wager is that enough thinning will release him from the chair. Livueta's verdict is non-reductionist. For her, identity is a further fact that neither time nor medicine nor merit can dissolve, and the novel ratifies her at least to this extent: the connections Elethiomel tries to thin are the ones that dominate his dreams. Yet the novel does not close the question. Its prologue and epilogue, set after the revelation, find him at war again; and *Surface Detail* (2010) ends by disclosing that one of its soldiers, Vatueil, is the man once called Zakalwe, still fighting under another name.

4.3 The ship of Theseus and the regrown body

Plutarch records that the Athenians preserved the ship of Theseus by replacing its rotten timbers, so that philosophers made it the standing example of the puzzle of growth and persistence (*Theseus* 23); Hobbes added the further difficulty of a second ship reassembled from the discarded planks (*De Corpore* II.11.7, 1655). Zakalwe's body is a ship of Theseus. Wounded and repaired across centuries, it is finally rebuilt entire around a preserved head, and when his lover, the poet Shias Engin, traces its scars, she finds a small puckered mark near the heart that makes him flinch.

The novel's ships give the puzzle three distinct solutions. The Culture's Minds, which inhabit ships and can be backed up and transferred, embody *pattern identity*, the self as information. The *Staberinde*, a dreadnought immobilized in stone and later

preserved as a museum piece in a public park, embodies *petrified identity*, the self frozen into the shape of its worst act and exhibited. The stone ship of the Zakalwe estate, a building set in water that only pretends to be a vessel, embodies *fictive identity*, the self as a game children play. Elethiomel has lived by all three: as a pattern restorable by Culture medicine, as a man fixed forever in the dry dock of the civil war, and as a player in a childhood fiction of being someone else.

4.4 Narrative identity: Ricoeur, MacIntyre, Strawson, Dennett

Paul Ricoeur's *Oneself as Another*, published in the same year as *Use of Weapons*, distinguishes *idem*-identity, sameness of character, from *ipse*-identity, selfhood as constancy, whose paradigm is keeping one's word; narrative identity mediates between them. Elethiomel has renounced *idem*: name, history, even body. What he retains is a perverse *ipse*, a fidelity to his own guilt. The only promise he keeps is the one he never made, to remember.

Alasdair MacIntyre argued that one can answer the question "What am I to do?" only by answering the prior question "Of what story or stories do I find myself a part?", and that to be the subject of a narrative is to be accountable for the actions that compose it (*After Virtue*, 1981, chapter 15). Elethiomel is the subject of a story whose first chapter he cannot tell, and his life achieves narrative unity only by suppressing it. Galen Strawson's "Against Narrativity" (2004) distinguished *episodic* selves, who do not experience their lives as extended narratives, from *diachronic* selves who do, and denied that narrativity is either universal or ethically required. The novel's form stages the dispute. The forward strand is lived episodically, mission by mission, in the present tense of adventure; the retrograde strand imposes from outside the diachronic narrative that the protagonist resists. Strawson governs one strand and MacIntyre the other, and the novel's ending is MacIntyre's victory.

Daniel Dennett described the self as a "center of narrative gravity", an abstraction posited by the stories a brain tells (1992). "Zakalwe" is a centre of narrative gravity spun around a void, and Dennett's further claim that the self is a useful fiction returns the argument to its title: the self is a tool, and this one was built for use.

4.5 Kripke, Evans and the guardian of reference

Saul Kripke argued that proper names are rigid designators, referring to the same individual in every possible world, and that their reference is fixed by an initial baptism transmitted along a causal chain of use rather than by any description speakers associate with the name (*Naming and Necessity*, 1972/1980). Gareth Evans's "The Causal

Theory of Names" (1973) complicated the picture with the case of Madagascar, a name that once denoted part of the African mainland and came, through Marco Polo's error, to denote the island. Reference can shift when a community's dominant source of information changes.

Use of Weapons is a Madagascar case staged as a tragedy. For two centuries and across a galactic civilization, "Zakalwe" has been used descriptively for the man who fights the Culture's wars, and by Evans's account the name may by now refer to Elethiomel for every community but one. Livueta belongs to the baptismal community, the witnesses who knew the original bearer, and her sentence at the climax is a semantic act that restores rigid designation: "Cheradenine Zakalwe, my brother, died nearly two hundred years ago." The sister is the guardian of reference. The aftermath is equally precise. The alias under which the man resurfaces in *Surface Detail*, Vatueil, is an anagram of Livueta: the name of the one who refused him, disarticulated and reassembled into a new form. It is an anagrammatic chair, a person's remains rebuilt into something that can be used.

4.6 Prosopopoeia and the face

Paul de Man argued that autobiography is not a genre but a figure of reading, and that its master trope is *prosopopoeia*, the fiction of an address from the dead that confers on them a face and a voice; but to give a face is also to deface ("Autobiography as De-facement", 1979). Elethiomel's life under Cheradenine's name is an enacted prosopopoeia. He lends the dead brother a face, his own, and speaks in the dead brother's name, and the novel's close focalization makes the reader complicit in the trope, reading a quasi-biography whose subject wears a borrowed face.

Emmanuel Levinas located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose first signification is the command not to kill (*Totality and Infinity*, 1961). The chair is the most extreme anti-Levinasian gesture imaginable: a person rendered faceless, her frame converted from that which looks back into that which is sat upon. Between the defacement of Darckense and the borrowed face of her brother, the novel describes a closed economy of faces, one taken away and one put on.

4.7 Comparators: Wolfe, Borges, Banks

Gene Wolfe's *The Fifth Head of Cerberus* (1972) is the speculative tradition's richest study of identity substitution: its narrator is a clone of his father, and its anthropologist, John V. Marsch, may have been killed and replaced by a shape-changing aboriginal who now writes as him, a colonial identity theft the book never resolves. Banks

resolves the substitution but not its meaning. Jorge Luis Borges's "Theme of the Traitor and the Hero" (1944) discovers that the martyred Irish conspirator Fergus Kilpatrick was the traitor, executed by his comrades in a theatrical assassination modelled on Shakespeare so that his death would serve the cause; the traitor survives in memory under the hero's form. Banks literalizes the conceit: the traitor survives in the flesh under the hero's name. Elethiomel's origins may sharpen the inversion. He was raised in the Zakalwe house as the son of a disgraced father; published summaries of the novel differ on whether the disgrace was treason or murder, and if it was treason, the traitor's son ends as the hero's namesake.

Banks's own first novel had already made identity reversal his signature. At the close of *The Wasp Factory* (1984) its narrator, Frank Cauldhame, learns that he was born female and that the story of his childhood mutilation was his father's fabrication. The device recurs across Banks's "M" and non-"M" fiction, but its polarity reverses between the two books. Frank is the victim of another's concealment; Elethiomel is the author of his own.

CHAPTER

5

The Ledger and the Unforgivable

Guilt, Repetition, Forgiveness

Guilt in Use of Weapons *is organized as debt and pursued as repayment, and the novel's deepest moral claim is that some debts are denominated in a currency the debtor does not possess.*

5.1 Nietzsche: debt, cruelty, forgetting

The second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) derives the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*). The oldest personal relation is that of creditor and debtor, and the creditor's original compensation is the right to inflict suffering on the defaulter (II.4–6). Memory itself was bred by a mnemotechnics of pain, because only what never ceases to hurt stays in the memory (II.3). Against this stands *active forgetting*, a positive faculty, a doorkeeper of psychic order without which there could be no happiness, no hope and no present (II.1). And at the summit of the genealogy stands an infinite debt that no debtor can repay, which Christianity resolved by having the creditor pay it himself (II.21).

Elethiomel's psyche is a failed Nietzschean economy. The doorkeeper does not hold; the chair returns in dream and reverie. Each mission for the Culture is an instalment on an infinite debt, and the novel's sharpest irony lies in the wage. The payment Zakalwe demands for the Voerenhutz mission is the location of Livueta. The mercenary asks to be paid with the address of his creditor. He wants not money but a summons, because only the creditor can cancel the debt, and the Culture, which can grow bodies and move stars, cannot forgive on another's behalf. *Beyond Good and Evil* §146 warned that whoever fights monsters must take care not to become one. Ele-

thiomel inverts the aphorism: having become the monster, he fights monsters on commission in the hope of becoming something else.

The novel also stages Nietzsche's thought of eternal recurrence (*The Gay Science* §341), in which a demon asks whether one could will one's life again, identically, in every detail. The double chronology compels the reader to relive the protagonist's life a second time in the light of its origin, and the protagonist fails the demon's test absolutely: there is one moment he cannot will. Culture longevity sharpens the predicament. An extended life does not outlive its past; it accumulates it.

5.2 Freud: repetition and afterwardsness

In "Remembering, Repeating and Working-Through" (1914) Freud observed that the patient repeats instead of remembering, acting out in deed what cannot be recalled in thought, and that analysis must convert repetition into recollection. *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) generalized repetition into a compulsion and illustrated it with Tasso's *Gerusalemme liberata*: Tancred unknowingly kills his beloved Clorinda, disguised in an enemy's armour, and later, in an enchanted forest, strikes a tall tree from whose wound blood flows and Clorinda's voice complains that he has wounded his beloved again. Cathy Caruth made the passage the foundation of trauma theory, reading in it the voice that cries out from the wound (*Unclaimed Experience*, 1996).

Elethiomel's wars are Tancred's sword in the forest. Every campaign re-wounds the beloved, and the text marks the repetition with clinical precision. In the forward strand he registers at a hotel under the name "Staberinde", signing with the name of the scene of his crime. In the retrograde strand, commanding a beaten army in a rainstorm, he has a captured enemy tied to a chair. Elsewhere he feeds a piece of a broken chair to a fire without noticing what it is. His body carries a small puckered scar near the heart that makes him flinch when a lover touches it; and in his own account of childhood a splinter of Darckense's bone, shattered by a stray shot, lodged in a boy's chest. The text thereby places, or lets its protagonist place, a fragment of the victim beside the perpetrator's heart. The decisive difference from Tasso is again epistemic. Tancred's first blow was ignorant and his repetition is the return of an experience never assimilated. Elethiomel's first act was lucid, and his repetition is the return of something fully known and wholly disowned.

Freud's concept of *Nachträglichkeit*, deferred action or, in Jean Laplanche's translation, *afterwardsness*, completes the analysis. In the case of Emma in the *Project for a Scientific Psychology* (1895), a childhood scene becomes traumatic only when a later scene confers on it a meaning it did not have; in the Wolf Man (1918) the primal scene is constituted retroactively. The novel enacts afterwardsness at the level of reading:

its earlier pages become traumatic only once the last page has been read. Laplanche added that what is retranslated afterwards is an enigmatic message implanted by another (*Essays on Otherness*, 1999). The chair is an enigmatic message in the most literal sense, a sign sent by an other to be decoded by its recipient. Banks's own description of his book as a set of concentric layers of defence invites the vocabulary of Anna Freud's *The Ego and the Mechanisms of Defence* (1936). Read concentrically, the novel arranges denial (the name), displacement (the wars), reaction formation (service in the cause of good) and isolation (the episodic life) as rings around a repressed core, and the reader breaches them from the outside in.

Freud's late paper "Constructions in Analysis" (1937) conceded that the analyst often cannot recover the repressed scene and must instead construct it, and that a patient's assured conviction in a correct construction can do the therapeutic work of a recaptured memory. Banks assigns that analytic labour to the text and its reader. The retrograde strand constructs the primal scene for us, and our conviction stands in for a confession the protagonist never makes in his own words: it is Livueta, not Elethiomel, who finally says what happened.

5.3 Moral luck, agent-regret and shame

Bernard Williams's "Moral Luck" (1976) argued that the justification of some choices depends on outcomes beyond the agent's control, and introduced *agent-regret*, the distinctive regret of a lorry driver who, through no fault of his own, runs over a child: a regret that attaches to *having done it*, not merely to its having happened. Thomas Nagel's companion essay (1976; 1979) distinguished resultant, circumstantial and constitutive luck. Elethiomel's case engages all three: circumstance placed him on the *Staberinde*; constitution gave him his gift for the use of weapons; and the chair produced its result. His subsequent career is an attempt to manufacture enough good resultant luck, enough wars won for good causes, to offset the bad. Williams's analysis explains why this cannot work. Agent-regret is indexed to particular acts and is not fungible across them. A ledger that sums outcomes is the wrong instrument for a regret that is not about outcomes. The Culture's own statistical ethic is a resultant-luck ethic writ large, and the novel uses its protagonist to expose its limit.

Williams's *Shame and Necessity* (1993) rehabilitated shame against the modern preference for guilt. Guilt concerns what one has done and seeks reparation; shame concerns what one is, arises under an imagined gaze, and expresses itself in the wish to disappear. Elethiomel's alias is the point at which shame and guilt fuse. Shame demands that he cease to be himself; guilt demands that he pay; he pays as someone else. The choice of *whose* name is not arbitrary. In the episodes of their youth,

Cheradenine is the brother who walked into the summerhouse and found Elethiomel and Darckense having sex on the small white chair Livueta had made. Cheradenine was the original witness, the eye before which Elethiomel was first exposed. To become Cheradenine is to escape the gaze by occupying the position of the one who looks. Identification with the witness is shame's most radical defence.

5.4 The literature of atonement

Three canonical atonement narratives define Elethiomel's position by contrast. Conrad's *Lord Jim* (1900) follows a young officer who abandons the pilgrim ship *Patna*, whose passengers in fact survive, and who spends his life atoning in Patusan, a society he can master, as "Tuan Jim". Marlow's circling, achronological narration and Jim's flight into the authority of an outsider among the less developed anticipate Banks closely. But Jim's fault is an omission and its consequences were spared by luck, and he atones by accepting death from Doramin. Elethiomel's fault is a commission whose consequences were total, and he atones by inflicting death on others.

Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment* (1866) gives Raskolnikov a utilitarian arithmetic, overheard in a tavern, of one death against a hundred lives, and a theory of extraordinary men entitled to step over blood. His redemption runs through confession and through Sonya, whose love accompanies him to Siberia. Elethiomel has the arithmetic, a calculus of military necessity, but no Sonya: the woman to whom he brings his confession refuses the role. Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* (1985) and *Speaker for the Dead* (1986) give the case of the weapon who did not know. Ender commits xenocide believing it a simulation, then spends millennia as the Speaker who tells the whole truth of the dead, carrying the cocoon from which the destroyed species can be restored. Ender's innocence makes him redeemable, and his universe supplies a means of restitution. Elethiomel's knowledge makes him useful, and his universe supplies none. There is no cocoon from which Darckense can be restored.

5.5 The philosophy of forgiveness

Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) identified forgiveness as the remedy for the irreversibility of action, as the promise is the remedy for its unpredictability; but she added that we are unable to forgive what we cannot punish, and unable to punish what has proved unforgivable. Such acts fall outside the realm of human affairs altogether. Vladimir Jankélévitch, after writing a treatise on forgiveness as a gratuitous event (*Le Pardon*, 1967), argued that crimes against humanity are imprescriptible, beyond the reach of time, and that forgiveness died in the death camps; he also asked, pointedly,

whether anyone had ever asked for it ("Pardonner?", 1971). Jacques Derrida answered with an aporia: forgiveness worthy of the name forgives only the unforgivable, since forgiving the forgivable is mere exchange; pure forgiveness is therefore impossible, unconditional and outside every economy, while conditional forgiveness, granted in return for repentance, belongs to therapy, reconciliation and politics ("On Forgiveness", 2001). Paul Ricoeur's epilogue to *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2000) concluded that forgiveness exists but is difficult, a height that answers the depth of fault.

The chair satisfies every definition of the unforgivable. It is imprescriptible in Jankélévitch's sense, and Culture longevity makes the imprescriptible literal: neither perpetrator nor witness will be released by death within any ordinary span. It is unpunishable in Arendt's sense, since no penalty could be proportionate to it. And it is exactly the kind of act for which Derrida's pure forgiveness is reserved. What Elethiomel seeks from Livueta, however, is not pure forgiveness but the conditional kind: an exchange of contrition and service for release. Chapter 11 will argue that her refusal, read through Derrida, is not the negation of forgiveness but the protection of its purity against a debtor who wants to buy it.

CHAPTER

6

The Chair and the Ship

Toward an Osteopoetics

The chair is the novel's central artifact because it collapses the distinction on which civilization rests, the distinction between making and unmaking; the ship is its counter-artifact, and the two together define the novel's ontology.

6.1 Scarry: making and unmaking

Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) argued that torture converts the prisoner's pain into the regime's fiction of power, and that it does so by *unmaking* the civilized world: the room, its door, its window, its bathtub and its chair are turned into weapons, so that the very shelter human beings built against the body's vulnerability becomes the instrument of its violation. The second half of the book reverses the analysis. *Making* is the projection of the body's sentience into the world, and artifacts are materialized perceptions of bodily need that, in relieving the body, remake their makers. Scarry's paradigm is the chair, the object that externalizes the body's perception of its own weight and so relieves the skeleton of its burden.

Elethiomel's chair collapses Scarry's distinction. It is an artifact whose function is the relief of the skeleton, built out of an actual skeleton: projection retracted into its source, making accomplished by unmaking. Scarry's reciprocity is inverted, since the object does not relieve its recipient but transmits pain to him. The bone chair is the *anti-artifact*, the object that does to the world what torture does to the room.

The novel embeds this inversion in a division of making established in childhood. The boys made knives and swords; Darckense made pots; Livueta made furniture for the summerhouse deep in the estate, including a small white chair. It was on that chair that Cheradenine, home from the military academy, found Darckense and Ele-

thiomel having sex, and it was the summerhouse that he, as a young major, later destroyed with a tank. The sisters were makers of vessels and seats, artifacts of containment and relief; the boys were makers of weapons. Elethiomel's chair fuses the three crafts into one object: Livueta's art of furniture, Darckense's body as material, his own art of the weapon. It is also a quotation, a sign legible to its recipient because it repeats the summerhouse chair. The most effective weapon, the novel suggests, is made from the private code of a family.

6.2 The Thyestean gift

The chair has a mythic genealogy. Atreus served his brother Thyestes a banquet of Thyestes' own sons and revealed the dish only after the meal (Aeschylus, *Agamemnon*, 458 BCE; Seneca, *Thyestes*). Procne served her husband Tereus the flesh of their son Itys in revenge for the rape and mutilation of her sister Philomela (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* VI). Shakespeare's Titus Andronicus baked Tamora's sons into a pie (c. 1592). The *Thyestean gift* has four features: the body of a kinsman or beloved; its transformation by craft into a domestic object; its delivery to an enemy; and the revelation of its nature after it has been received. The chair possesses all four. Darckense was beloved of both men; Elethiomel had her killed and her remains made into furniture; he sent the object across the lines of a civil war; and its meaning detonated on recognition, driving her brother to suicide.

Banks thereby transposes the curse of the house of Atreus into space opera. The Zakalwe household is Atreid, and Livueta occupies Electra's position, the surviving sister who keeps the memory of the dead. Unlike Electra she does not want vengeance. The *Oresteia* closes when Athena founds a court and persuades the Furies to become the Eumenides, so that institutional justice replaces the vendetta. The Culture, which might have played Athena, founds no court. It offers employment. The Furies are therefore never domesticated; they survive as the protagonist's nightmares.

6.3 Kafka's apparatus and Borges's murdered message

In Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) an apparatus inscribes the violated commandment into the body of the condemned over twelve hours, and around the sixth hour, the officer explains, understanding dawns as the condemned deciphers the script with his wounds. When the visiting explorer declines to endorse the machine, the officer frees the prisoner, sets the apparatus to inscribe "Be just!" and lays himself beneath it; the machine malfunctions and kills him without the promised illumination. The chair is a body-message of the same kind, and its maker's subsequent career re-

peats the officer's end. Elethiomel lays himself in the Culture's apparatus, to be wounded, beheaded and rebuilt, awaiting an illumination that the machine is not built to deliver.

In Borges's "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), the spy Yu Tsun must transmit to Berlin the name of a British artillery park, the town of Albert. He murders a sinologist named Stephen Albert, knowing that the newspaper reports of the murder will carry the name to his chief. A man is killed in order to become a signifier. The chair is semiotic warfare in exactly this sense: its military value lies wholly in what it says, namely that its maker will do anything. Borges's title supplies, besides, an image of the double chronology, a garden of paths that fork and reconverge.

6.4 Chiastic ontology: three ships and a chair

The novel pairs its two central artifacts in its own imagery. Late in the book, the protagonist's mind sets the *Staberinde*, a metal ship stuck in stone, beside the stone ship of the estate, "a building stuck in water". The pairing is a chiasmus, and it is the novel's ontological grammar. A third term completes it: the Culture's ships, which are Minds, persons with names, wit and moral standing. Among them is the *Xenophobe*, a starship of a warship class the Culture calls Torturer, whose Mind is a person and whose body is a weapon. The Culture's drone Skaffen-Amtiskaw, which once saved Sma's life by slaughtering her assailants with conspicuous savagery, is likewise a person who is a weapon.

The chiasmus runs as follows. The Culture's metaphysical generosity elevates things to persons: ships, drones and habitats become subjects. Its practical politics, and Elethiomel's war, reduce persons to things: agents become instruments and a sister becomes a chair. The traffic runs both ways at every scale, down to the detail in which a sophisticated combat suit ends its career as a razor, a weapon reduced to a tool, while the chair is a tool raised into a weapon. The Minds embody both directions at once, persons whose bodies are arsenals, and they thereby occupy what Agamben would call a zone of indistinction between person and instrument. The question the novel asks of the Culture is not whether it respects persons, which it does lavishly, but whether anything in it is *merely* a thing or *merely* a person.

The *Staberinde* has an afterlife that completes the argument. On the protagonist's homeworld it has become a museum piece in a public park, and he visits it on the way to Livueta. Benjamin warned that a humanity sufficiently alienated from itself could experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure ("The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility", 1935–36). The dreadnought turned monument undergoes the same conversion as the chair, weapon into furniture of

public life, but under the sanction of heritage. A society sits in its park beside its fortress as Cheradenine was meant to sit before the chair.

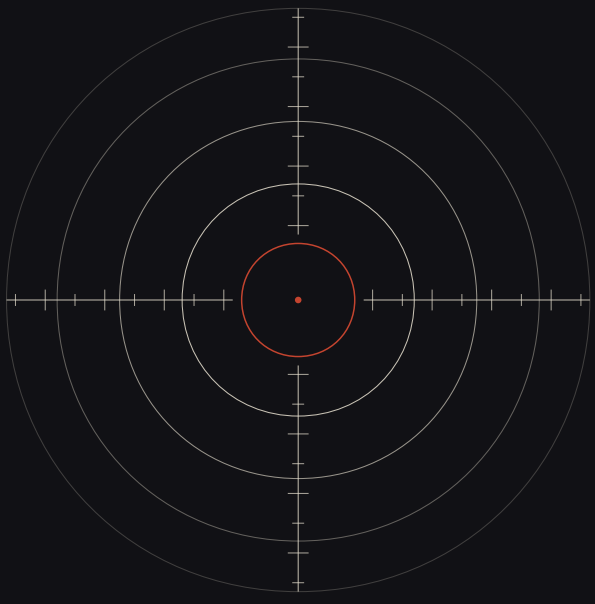
6.5 Frankenstein and the made person

Mary Shelley's Victor Frankenstein collects bones from charnel houses to build a person, then destroys the half-finished female companion he has promised his creature (*Frankenstein*, 1818). Banks inverts the procedure: from a person, bones; from bones, a thing. Shelley's nested confession is framed by Walton's ship trapped in Arctic ice, a vessel immobilized at the edge of the known world, as the *Staberinde* is immobilized in stone. Shelley's made person has no name. The man who had Darckense killed took her brother's name for two centuries and, by the novel's own account, once built an alias out of something like the sisters' names.

6.6 Osteopoetics defined

The foregoing analyses can now be stated as a method. *Osteopoetics* rests on three axioms. First, every made thing rests on an armature, frequently a body, whose visibility is inversely proportional to the thing's usability: one cannot comfortably sit on a chair one knows to be one's sister, enjoy a utopia whose special circumstances one has seen, or relish an adventure whose hero one knows to be the Chairmaker. Second, conversion across the boundary between persons and things runs in both directions, and its direction is the primary datum of ethical reading. Third, the meaning of a made thing is completed only at its reception, so that all reading is reading-after.

Viktor Shklovsky held that art exists to restore sensation, to make the stone stony ("Art as Device", 1917). Banks makes the chair chairy. After the last page, every chair in the novel becomes, in Heidegger's term, conspicuous, and for a moment so does every chair in the reader's room.



PART THREE

III

Constellations

Fictions of benevolent power, and the reader inside the machine

CHAPTER

7

Agents of Benevolent Power

A Comparative Constellation

Read against the long tradition of speculative fiction about benevolent powers and their agents, Use of Weapons *marks the point at which the tradition turns its gaze from the principal to the instrument.*

7.1 Hidden benefactors: Arisia, Terminus, the Bene Gesserit

Banks said the Culture let him answer the right-wing American space opera that had flourished since the 1930s, and the form's founding text shows what was being answered. In E. E. "Doc" Smith's *Lensman* sequence (1934–1948) an ancient benevolent race, the Arisians, steers galactic history across aeons, breeding human bloodlines toward the Kinnison line and the Children of the Lens in order to defeat the Eddorians. The Lensmen are the instruments of a hidden benevolent intelligence, and Smith presents the arrangement without a shadow of irony. The Culture retains its structure, a superior intelligence acting through human agents, and restores the moral cost Smith omitted. *Use of Weapons* is *Lensman* read by a conscience.

Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* trilogy (1951–1953) imagines a statistical science of history, Hari Seldon's psychohistory, guarded by a secret Second Foundation of mental adepts. Its premise is that individuals do not matter in the aggregate, and its great crisis, the Mule, is the individual who breaks the statistics. Banks turns the premise around: statistics act *through* individuals, and the individual through whom they act pays the cost that the aggregate conceals. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) supplies the breeding programme and the planted myth, the Bene Gesserit's Missionaria Protectiva, and in Paul Atreides an instrument who seizes the role of principal and cannot stop the holy war he foresees. Zakalwe never becomes a principal. His tragedy is

the opposite of Paul's: not that the instrument usurps the hand, but that it consents to remain in it.

7.2 The Strugatskys: the observer and the foundling

Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Hard to Be a God* (1964) sends an Earth historian, Anton, disguised as the nobleman Don Rumata, into the medieval kingdom of Arkanar under strict instructions to observe and never to kill. For years he watches literacy persecuted and a fascist religious order rise; when the woman he loves is murdered, his restraint breaks and he kills his way through the city. *Beetle in the Anthill* (1979) turns the same utopian future inward. Lev Abalkin, one of thirteen children grown from embryos left by the vanished Wanderers, may be a sleeper weapon without knowing it, and the head of Earth's security service, Rudolf Sikorski, shoots him dead when he reaches for an artefact that may be his trigger.

Together with Banks's novel these books form a matrix of four positions. Rumata is the utopian agent *forbidden* to use weapons, broken by non-intervention. Zakalwe is the utopian agent *paid* to use them, broken by intervention. Abalkin is the man who may be a weapon without knowing it, killed by utopia on suspicion. Elethiomel is the man who knows he has been a weapon and conceals it, employed by utopia for his proven capacity. The Strugatskys' Noon universe and Banks's Culture converge on one structural thesis: every utopia grows a secret organ of exception, COMCON-2 in the one case and Special Circumstances in the other.

7.3 Non-intervention: the Ekumen and the Prime Directive

Ursula K. Le Guin's Hainish Ekumen is the anti-SC. In *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) its First Mobile, Genly Ai, comes to Gethen alone and unarmed, because a single alien is a curiosity while two would be an invasion; contact proceeds by persuasion or not at all. Le Guin knew the alternative. In *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972) Terran colonists teach the peaceful Athsheans to kill, and their leader Selver, who learns murder in order to resist, becomes a god in the Athshean sense, a translator who brings a new thing into the world. Contact there transmits the use of weapons itself. Star Trek's Prime Directive codified liberal non-intervention as a categorical rule.

Banks's novel does not choose between the Culture and the Ekumen. It shows that every policy toward the less powerful allocates a cost, that non-intervention allocates it to the victims of local tyrannies and intervention to the agents who carry it out, and

that the decisive ethical question is therefore not *whether* to act but *who will bear the act*.

7.4 Lem's *Fiasco*: contact as bombardment

Stanisław Lem's last novel, *Fiasco* (1986), sends a human expedition to establish contact with the civilization of the planet Quinta. Frustrated by silence, the expedition escalates through demonstrations of force intended as messages, until communication and bombardment become indistinguishable and the encounter ends in catastrophe. Its protagonist is a pilot revived from the frozen remains of one of two men, uncertain which of them he is. Lem's novel isolates the principle that underlies the chair at civilizational scale: under extreme asymmetry of power, violence becomes a language, and a demonstration of capacity becomes a sentence addressed to the other. Lem's reconstituted pilot, unsure whose life he continues, is Elethiomel's distant cousin.

7.5 Imperial agents: Conrad and Greene

Kurtz in Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (1899) goes out as an emissary of pity, science and progress and writes for the International Society for the Suppression of Savage Customs an eloquent report whose scrawled postscript reads "Exterminate all the brutes!" The agent of enlightenment becomes its weapon, and the Company's hands remain clean. Marlow returns to tell Kurtz's Intended a consoling lie about his last words. Livueta is the Intended's antithesis: the woman to whom the agent of empire comes home, who already knows the truth and refuses to let it be softened.

Graham Greene's *The Quiet American* (1955) offers the opposite pathology. Alden Pyle, an idealistic agent armed with a book's theory of a Third Force, supplies explosives that kill civilians in a Saigon square, and remains innocent in the dangerous sense Greene's narrator Fowler despises. The Culture is not Pyle. Its principals are knowing, its models are good and its agents are anything but innocent. If Pyle is innocence armed, SC is knowledge armed, and Zakalwe is the figure in whom knowledge pays.

7.6 Banks against Banks: the Culture sequence as self-revision

Use of Weapons is the hinge of a sequence that interrogates its utopia from successively different angles. *Consider Phlebas* (1987) sees the Culture from the outside, through the shape-changer Horza, who fights for the Idirans because he despises a civilization that has handed its fate to machines; its appendices reduce the Idiran war

to statistics. *The Player of Games* (1988) shows SC blackmailing a citizen, the game-player Gurgeh, into service, and is narrated by a drone that withholds its identity until the end. *Use of Weapons* turns from the citizen-instrument to the non-citizen instrument, and from blackmail to wage.

The later novels extend the argument. In *Excession* (1996) a cabal of Minds manufactures a war. *Inversions* (1998) never names the Culture, presenting two expatriates on a feudal world whose practices, a physician's activist meliorism and a bodyguard's protective restraint, stage the intervention debate from within. *Look to Windward* (2000) concerns a caste war precipitated by Culture interference and the guilt of a Mind that fought in the Idiran war. *Matter* (2008) gives SC an agent born into a feudal society, Djan Seriy Anaplian, who returns home. *Surface Detail* (2010), in which a war over virtual hells is fought by soldiers repeatedly killed and resurrected, closes by revealing that its soldier Vatueil is the man once called Zakalwe. *The Hydrogen Sonata* (2012) closes the sequence with a man who has lived ten thousand years and remembers what others have forgotten. Across a quarter-century Banks returned again and again to the questions *Use of Weapons* had made unavoidable: who acts for utopia, who pays, and who remembers.

CHAPTER

8

The Reader in the Chair

Displaced Anagnorisis and the Ethics of the Twist

The recognition that Aristotle assigned to the tragic hero is, in Use of Weapons*, transferred to the reader, and the transfer makes the reader the novel's last recipient of the chair.*

8.1 Displaced anagnorisis

Aristotle defined recognition (*anagnōrisis*) as a change from ignorance to knowledge that produces love or hatred between persons marked for good or bad fortune, and judged it finest when it coincides with reversal, as in *Oedipus* (*Poetics* 1452a). The first kind of recognition he lists is recognition by signs, including scars (1454b), and the canonical instance is Eurycleia recognizing Odysseus by the boar-scar on his thigh, the scene with which Erich Auerbach opened *Mimesis* (1946). Auerbach contrasted the Homeric style, which keeps everything in a uniformly illuminated foreground, with the style of Genesis, which leaves its decisive matters "fraught with background", and his example of the latter was Abraham leading Isaac to the sacrifice.

Banks's two strands distribute Auerbach's two styles. The forward strand is Homeric: present-tense adventure, externalized, lit evenly from end to end. The retrograde strand is fraught with background, and what lies in its background is, as in Genesis, the sacrifice of a beloved to a higher purpose. The scar is present too. A lover traces the protagonist's scars and finds the puckered mark near his heart, a sign that could have produced recognition and does not. In Homer the scar reveals identity to the one who touches it. In Banks it conceals identity from everyone except the one who bears it, and recognition is postponed until it can fall on the reader.

This is the decisive formal fact. Oedipus does not know who he is; the play's anagnorisis happens to him. Elethiomel has always known; the anagnorisis happens to us. The love that Aristotle says recognition converts into hatred is the reader's love for the protagonist, built across the forward strand, and the reversal is a reversal in the reader's fortunes as a moral observer. I call this structure *displaced anagnorisis*.

8.2 Paralipsis and the good soldier

Gérard Genette named *paralipsis* the narrative figure in which the narration omits information that its focal character possesses, and the classic example is Agatha Christie's *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd* (1926), whose narrator conceals throughout that he is the murderer (Genette 1980). *Use of Weapons* is paralipsis raised to ethical seriousness. Its narration is focalized closely through the protagonist and never lies, but it calls him by a name that is not his and withholds the one fact that organizes his consciousness. The novel's first part bears the title "The Good Soldier", and the borrowing from Ford Madox Ford is exact. Ford's *The Good Soldier* (1915) is the modern novel's paradigm of digressive, time-shifting retrospection, in which a narrator circles a story whose central facts are disclosed late and the soldier of the title turns out to be other than he seemed. Banks takes Ford's method and gives it a second clock.

8.3 Surprised by sin

Stanley Fish argued that *Paradise Lost* works by tempting its reader into error, admiring Satan's grandeur or misreading the narrator, and then correcting the error, so that the reader re-enacts the Fall and the poem's true subject becomes the reader's own fallen perception (*Surprised by Sin*, 1967). *Use of Weapons* surprises its reader by sin in the same way. It offers a charismatic, wounded, witty soldier fighting for the good, invites identification and then reveals what the reader has identified with. Wayne Booth's account of the implied author, whose norms the reader shares behind the narrator's back (*The Rhetoric of Fiction*, 1961), describes the complicity Banks withholds and then grants too late. Wolfgang Iser's theory of textual gaps, the blanks the reader must fill to realize the work (*The Act of Reading*, 1976), describes Banks's method of construction. The novel's gaps are designed so that the reader fills them with humanizing material, and that material is precisely what the revelation destroys. Banks weaponizes the reader's contribution.

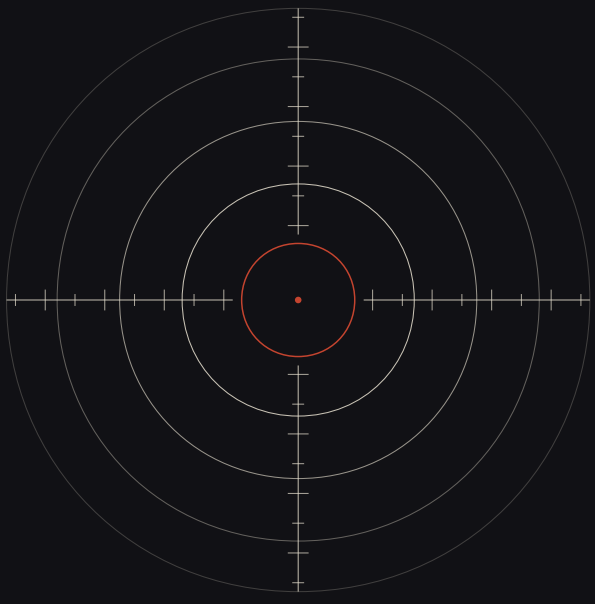
8.4 Complicity

Three years after *Use of Weapons*, Banks published *Complicity* (1993), a thriller whose first-person narrator is a left-wing journalist and whose murder scenes are narrated in the second person, so that the reader is addressed as the killer. The later novel makes explicit what the earlier one performs: reading is a form of participation, and the reader's pleasure is implicated in the violence that produces it. *The Wasp Factory* had already drawn its reader into intimacy with a child's cruelty. Across his career, in both his literary and his science fiction, Banks treated the reader as a party to the text, not its spectator.

8.5 The ethics of the twist

The twist is commonly suspected of being a gimmick that trades meaning for surprise, and some readers have complained that the revelation in *Use of Weapons* requires a transformation, from war criminal to hero of the good, that the novel never shows. The objection mistakes the novel's claim. It does not show the arc because there is no arc. Elethiomel has not been converted; he has been renamed. The absence of a visible transformation is the novel's indictment of the idea that a ledger of good deeds can constitute one.

The twist is ethical rather than merely informational for three reasons. It is prepared consistently: the chair recurs throughout the retrograde strand and the name *Staberinde* surfaces in the forward one. It changes evaluation rather than mere fact, converting the forward strand on rereading into tragic irony. And it compels a second reading that functions, in Freud's terms, as the working-through of the first reading's acting-out. Above all, the twist places the reader in the Culture's position. The reader has used Zakalwe, as a vehicle for adventure, wit and vicarious competence, just as the Culture used him for outcomes. Our pleasure in his campaigns was a use of weapons. When the revelation comes, the reader faces the Culture's own dilemma: having profited from the instrument, do we disown it, or do we admit what our use of it required? The reader becomes Special Circumstances.



PART FOUR

IV

The Theorem

The Chairmaker's Theorem, the moral crumple zone and the unusable

CHAPTER

9

The Chairmaker's Theorem

Stated formally, the Chairmaker's Theorem specifies the condition under which a person becomes a weapon and the four consequences that follow; the novel instantiates it at three scales, and their isomorphism is its deepest argument.

9.1 Definitions and statement

Let a *principal* P be an agent that seeks to produce an effect E in a *recipient* R. The *mediacy condition* holds when P cannot or will not produce E by acting directly on R, whether from incapacity (P is besieged), from constraint (norms, legitimacy or self-image forbid P to appear as author), or from the nature of E itself (a meaning that must arrive from within R's own world). A *medium* M is a third body through which the act passes. *Weaponization* is the conversion of M into a bearer of strategic affect, such that M's significance for R consists in what M has been made to mean rather than in what M is.

Theorem. Under the mediacy condition, the production of E requires the weaponization of M, and weaponization entails four consequences.

1. **Instrumental reduction.** M is treated merely as a means in the precise respect of its mediation, however fully M is treated as an end in every other respect.
2. **Agential displacement.** E presents itself to R as emanating from M rather than from P.
3. **Semantic deferral.** The meaning of E is completed only on reception; the act remains unfinished until it arrives, and it is constituted afterwards.
4. **Recursive conversion.** P's successful weaponization of M demonstrates a capacity that renders P available for weaponization by a higher principal.

Concealment lemma. The usability of a made thing produced under the mediacy condition varies inversely with the visibility of its medium. Disclosure of the medium is, in Heidegger's sense, a breakdown: the thing becomes conspicuous and can no longer be used as before. The novel's revelation is truth as *alētheia*, unconcealment, and it breaks the novel as an entertainment in the act of completing it as a work.

Boundary condition. Not all mediation is weaponization. An ambassador carries a message on which all parties can agree, and is used as a means to which everyone could consent. By O'Neill's criterion (Chapter 2), weaponization begins where the recipient could not consent to being acted upon through this medium in this way. The criterion explains why the theorem applies to fiction only in an attenuated form, discussed below.

9.2 Three instantiations

SCALE	PRINCIPAL	MEDIUM	RECIPIENT	EFFECT	MEDIACY CONDITION
Domestic	Elethiomel	Darckense, made into the chair	Cheradenine	Collapse of will	Besieged in the *Staberinde*; cannot win by force
Civilizational	The Culture, through SC	"Zakalwe"	Target societies; the Culture's own self-image	Steered history; preserved innocence	Norms of non-attribution; legitimacy; the citizens' conscience
Textual	Banks	The protagonist, delivered by the double chronology	The reader	Destruction of sympathy; compelled rereading	A moral weight that cannot be stated, only delivered

At the **domestic** scale the four consequences are exact. Elethiomel has Darckense killed and her body reduced to material (instrumental reduction). Cheradenine is confronted not by Elethiomel but by his sister, who is made to wound her brother (agential displacement). The chair's meaning completes itself only in Cheradenine's recognition, because it quotes the small white chair of the summerhouse, a private sign only he can read (semantic deferral). And the capacity it demonstrates, Elethiomel's use of weapons, is precisely what the Culture will later hire (recursive conversion).

At the **civilizational** scale the agent is paid, healed and consulted, but in the respect of his mediation he is merely a means, the non-attributable hand. Target populations experience his generalship as local politics, not as the Culture's will. The meaning of each intervention completes itself only in an aftermath measured in decades, and in the Culture's narrative of itself as a force for good. The fourth consequence operates at the level of composition: by Banks's own account the Culture was invented as the setting a moral mercenary would need. The utopia is the author's instrument, built around the weapon it would employ.

At the **textual** scale the protagonist is the medium through which Banks delivers what cannot be stated. The shock of the ending appears to come from the character rather than from the author, whose construction withdraws behind it. The meaning of the whole is completed only on the last page and on rereading. And the reader, having received the chair, becomes a medium in turn, carrying it outward in conversation, criticism and theory. The present thesis is itself a chair built from the novel's bones, and the theorem predicts as much.

Fiction stands at the boundary condition. The reader consents in general to be moved, deceived and surprised by a novel, but not specifically to be indicted. The twist operates through this generic licence, a consent given in advance to a category of experience and exercised on a particular that the reader would not have chosen. The attenuation is real, and it is also the source of the form's power: literature is the one domain in which a person may consent, in advance, to be used as the recipient of a weapon.

9.3 The chairmaker becomes the chair

The fourth consequence is the novel's version of justice. Elethiomel is not punished; he is repeated. Having converted Darckense into a medium for his will, he converts himself into a medium for the Culture's, and the Culture's craftsmanship on his body completes the symmetry. It repairs him as furniture is repaired, re-joints him after wounds and, after a beheading, rebuilds an entire body around a preserved head. Culture medicine is a form of joinery. Kafka's officer laid himself in the apparatus he had

served; Elethiomel lays himself in the apparatus of the Culture, and the illumination he awaits, the forgiveness of the sister who survived, is not something the apparatus can produce.

The recursion does not end with him. The coda "States of War" shows Sma recruiting another war-damaged agent, and the frame shows the protagonist at war again after the revelation. The theorem predicts this persistence. A civilization that solves the mediacy condition by weaponizing persons must keep finding persons to weaponize, and every successful weaponization, by demonstrating the capacity it requires, creates a candidate for the next. The chair is not an event in the Culture's history. It is a recurring structure, and its makers become its material.

CHAPTER

10

The Moral Crumple Zone of Utopia

The one function the Culture cannot automate is attributability, and the animate instrument that Aristotle's counterfactual should have abolished therefore returns at the margin of utopia as the being to whom violence is assigned.

10.1 The Aristotelian remainder

The Culture realizes Aristotle's dream of self-moving tools, and an early line of the novel registers the consequence with laconic precision: "Utopia spawns few warriors." A civilization without scarcity, hierarchy or enemies at home produces neither the experience of violence nor the appetite for it; when it needs a general, it must import one. The obvious explanation, that the Culture lacks the capacity for violence, is false within the novel's own world. Its drones kill, as Skaffen-Amtiskaw has demonstrated; its warships are, in their own bantering estimation, capable of wasting planets; and its Minds could direct any war more efficiently than any human. The Culture does not hire the mercenary because it cannot fight. It hires him because it must not be seen, by others or by itself, to be the one fighting.

Four requirements explain the hire. The first is *legibility*: target societies must be able to read the forces shaping their history as their own, whereas a Mind's direct action would reveal that their history has an author. The second is *attributability*: an act performed by a Culture Mind is an act of the Culture, while an act performed by a mercenary is, in the first instance, the mercenary's. The third is *moral economy*: the Culture's citizens must be able to go on believing that their civilization does not kill except in self-defence. The fourth is *deniability* toward peer civilizations that might otherwise prove authorship. None of these requirements is technical. All are normat-

ive. What survives perfect automation is not a task that machines cannot perform but a *position* that machines cannot occupy without transferring its moral weight to the system they belong to: the position of the one to whom the act is attributed.

Hence the proposition stated in the abstract: *in a fully automated civilization, the last human occupation is to be the one to whom the act is attributed*. Aristotle's slave was the instrument whose work was the use of the body. The Culture's mercenary is the instrument whose work is the bearing of the act.

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) supplies the theological shape of this division. Its pseudonymous author contrasts the tragic hero, Agamemnon sacrificing his daughter Iphigenia so that the fleet may sail for Troy, who remains within the ethical because he sacrifices for its higher expression, the state, with Abraham, whose *teleological suspension of the ethical* can be neither mediated nor universalized nor explained. The Atreid house returns once more, for Agamemnon is the son of Atreus, and the sacrifice of a beloved kinswoman to the requirements of war is the mythic precedent of the chair. Special Circumstances accomplishes what Kierkegaard declared impossible. It institutionalizes the teleological suspension of the ethical, on the warrant not of faith but of statistics, and it divides the labour: the Minds decide the exception as Abraham's God commands it, and the mercenary performs the sacrifice as Agamemnon did.

10.2 Responsibility gaps and meaningful human control

Andreas Matthias argued that learning automata, whose behaviour neither their makers nor their operators can fully predict, open a *responsibility gap* in which no one can justly be held responsible for their acts (Matthias 2004). Robert Sparrow drew the military conclusion: because neither the programmer, nor the commander, nor the machine can properly be held responsible for a killing by an autonomous weapon, and because the laws of war require that someone answer for every death, deploying such weapons would be unethical (Sparrow 2007). The policy response has crystallized in the doctrine of *meaningful human control* (Santoni de Sio and van den Hoven 2018) and its regulatory analogues. United States Department of Defense Directive 3000.09 (2012, revised 2023) requires that autonomous and semi-autonomous weapon systems be designed to allow commanders and operators to exercise appropriate levels of human judgment over the use of force. Article 14 of the European Union's Artificial Intelligence Act (Regulation (EU) 2024/1689) requires that high-risk systems be designed for effective human oversight. In each instrument, the human is kept in the loop in order both to *control* and to *answer*.

The Culture's arrangement shows what happens when those two functions come apart. Its Minds do not need Zakalwe's judgment; they model wars better than he fights them. They retain him for the second function alone. He is not a means of human control but of human answerability; the loop contains a human not because the human steers but because the human can be blamed. I call this *meaningful human blame*: the retention of a human in an automated system for the purpose of attribution rather than control. The Culture closes the responsibility gap not by restoring human agency but by installing a human placeholder for it.

The speculative case meets the empirical one in the literature on automation bias. Human supervisors of automated systems tend toward complacency and toward accepting automated recommendations they are nominally empowered to override (Parasuraman and Manzey 2010). Oversight decays into ratification, and a human formally in the loop who cannot meaningfully contest the system's outputs supplies the appearance of human judgment together with the reality of human liability.

10.3 The moral crumple zone and alignment laundering

Madeleine Clare Elish coined the term *moral crumple zone* for the way responsibility for the failure of a highly automated system is misattributed to a human operator who had limited control over its behaviour. As the crumple zone of a car absorbs the force of a collision to protect the occupants, the human absorbs moral and legal responsibility, protecting the integrity of the technological system (Elish 2019). Elish's cases come from nuclear power and aviation, and in them the crumple zone is an emergent effect, a failure of attribution.

Use of Weapons imagines the crumple zone as design. Zakalwe's body is a literal crumple zone, absorbing impact after impact, wound after wound, even a beheading, while his name absorbs the moral force of the Culture's interventions and the Minds remain intact and innocent. Elish identified misattribution as a pathology of automation; Banks depicted it as a policy of utopia, the deliberate engineering of a human surface whose function is to receive the blame that would otherwise reach the machine. Three decades before the term existed, the novel diagnosed the crumple zone and showed what a benevolent civilization would do with it: not abolish it, but staff it.

The point can be put in the vocabulary of AI safety. Nick Bostrom's *orthogonality thesis* holds that intelligence and final goals vary independently, and his *instrumental convergence thesis* that agents with very different goals will converge on certain instrumental subgoals, such as self-preservation and the acquisition of resources (Bostrom 2014). The Culture's Minds are the canonical fiction of aligned superintelligence: be-

nevolent, humane and witty. The novel adds a convergent instrumental goal that the alignment literature has not named. An aligned system constrained by norms of legitimacy will tend to acquire human proxies through which its compromised actions can be routed. I call the result *alignment laundering*: the preservation of a system's apparent alignment by passing its ethically costly actions through human agents who bear their attribution. Stuart Russell's model of beneficial machines has them defer to humans because they are uncertain about human preferences (*Human Compatible*, 2019). The Minds defer to a human for a different reason: not because they are uncertain what is good, but because they have concluded that someone other than themselves must be seen to do it. Deference becomes a technique of moral insulation.

10.4 Exo-Omelas and the guilty mercenary

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) argued that sovereignty's originary act is the production of bare life, included in the political order only in the form of its exclusion: the figure who may be killed but not sacrificed. Zakalwe, born outside the Culture, is recruited into its operations and excluded from its moral community; his killings are not Culture killings, and his death would not be a Culture death. He enters the Culture's history in the form of his absence from its ledger. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) located the sovereign right to kill in the colony, the zone in which the norms of the metropole are suspended. The Culture's contact frontier functions in the same way: the anarchist commonwealth's norms hold inside it, and beyond it special circumstances apply.

Machiavelli warned in chapter 12 of *The Prince* that mercenaries are useless and dangerous: faithless, undisciplined and unwilling to die for a stipend too small to justify it. The Culture solves Machiavelli's problem by hiring a mercenary whose loyalty is secured not by pay but by debt. The guilty mercenary is the perfect mercenary, because he fights for expiation, and expiation, unlike a wage, can never be paid in full. The Culture's choice of instrument is therefore not incidental to Elethiomel's crime. Whether or not its Minds know what the crime was, they know the kind of man it produced, and the chair is at once his qualification and his bond. Exo-Omelas (Chapter 3) is thereby completed. The child outside the walls is not merely exported; he is selected for his guilt.

10.5 The responsibility frontier

Marx placed the realm of freedom beyond the realm of necessity, and the Culture has crossed that frontier. *Use of Weapons* discovers a second frontier beyond the first. The

realm of freedom is bordered not only by necessity but by responsibility, which can be neither automated nor socialized, only outsourced. The Culture has abolished every kind of labour but one, the labour of being answerable. Its utopia rests on a single remaining job, and the man who holds it is the Chairmaker.

CHAPTER

11

The Unusable

Refusal, Inoperativity and the Ethics of the Remainder

In a novel in which everything can be used, one act cannot: Livueta's refusal, which declines to let her sister be used a second time.

11.1 The scene of refusal

After the Voerenhutz mission, gravely wounded and refusing the Culture's medicine, the protagonist insists on being taken to Livueta. On his homeworld he passes the *Staberinde*, now a museum piece in a park, and finds her, aged and white-haired, working as a nurse in a hospital city. He weeps. She rejects him, and tells him who he is.

The refusal is not vengeance, for she does him no harm. It is not justice, for she convenes no tribunal and demands no penalty. It is not even condemnation in the ordinary sense. It is a refusal to complete the transaction he has crossed the galaxy to conclude, and it has three objects. She refuses forgiveness. She refuses the name, correcting its reference. And she refuses a role the Culture has already assigned her. Her location was the wage Zakalwe demanded for the Voerenhutz mission, so that the Culture, in finding her, converted her into payment. Livueta declines to be spent.

11.2 The second use of Darckense

Forgiveness, had it been granted, would have been put to use. Elethiomel would have used it to close the ledger and become at last the man whose name he wears. The Culture would have used it to repair its instrument, returning to service a weapon freed of the defect that made it unpredictable. Within the economy of the novel, for-

giveness is a currency, and the currency is denominated in Darckense: her death would become the coin with which her murderer purchases his peace. The first use made her a chair. The second would make her a receipt.

Livueta refuses the second use. That she is a nurse is not incidental. She cares for bodies, and the last service she can render her sister's body is to refuse to let it be used again. Her refusal is the novel's only act of care toward Darckense, and it takes the form of a negation because, in a world organized by use, care for the dead can only appear as a withholding.

11.3 Pure means and the general strike

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) argued that all legal violence either makes law or preserves it, and that both belong to the order of means and ends. He sought instead *pure means*, forms of action outside instrumental relation, and found examples in non-violent agreement through language and in the proletarian general strike as Georges Sorel had theorized it (*Réflexions sur la violence*, 1908). The political strike extorts concessions and so remains within the economy it bargains with; the general strike sets no conditions and aims at no modification of the existing order, but simply stops.

Livueta's refusal is a general strike against the economy of absolution. She withdraws the one labour the system cannot perform without her, the labour of forgiving, and thereby halts a machine that would otherwise convert her sister's death into its agent's peace. She does not bargain, set terms or demand penance. She stops. Benjamin distinguished the mythic violence that founds law, the violence of the curse of Atreus, from a divine violence that annihilates it. Livueta's act is neither violence nor law. It is a pure means, a gesture that serves no end.

11.4 Bartleby and inoperativity

Melville's scrivener answers every request with the formula "I would prefer not to" ("Bartleby, the Scrivener", 1853). Gilles Deleuze read the formula as an agrammatical hollowing-out of the language of preference and command (1989); Giorgio Agamben read Bartleby as the figure of pure potentiality, the potential *not* to, in which contingency is preserved against its exhaustion in act (1993). Agamben later developed the concept of *inoperativity*, which names not inertia but an activity that deactivates the works and functions of life and so opens them to a new use, and the related figure of "means without end" (1996). In *The Use of Bodies* (2014), the final volume of the *Homo Sacer* project, he returns to Aristotle's definition of the slave as the being

whose work is the use of the body, and proposes that use (*chrēsis*) names a relation prior to the division of subject and object, a use that is not instrumental. *The Highest Poverty* (2011) had found its model in the Franciscan *usus pauper*, use without ownership.

Agamben's project and Banks's novel share a title in all but name. Both are inquiries into the use of bodies. Agamben seeks a use beyond instrumentality; Banks finds only one gesture that escapes instrumentality, and it is not a use at all but a refusal, inoperativity in its starkest form. Livueta renders forgiveness inoperative. She deactivates the machine of absolution without destroying the possibility of forgiveness itself, holding open, in Agamben's terms, a potential that she declines to actualize in this exchange. Read with Derrida (Chapter 5), her refusal protects pure forgiveness, which would have to be unconditional and outside every economy, from its counterfeit, the conditional forgiveness that a debtor can earn.

11.5 The separateness of persons

John Rawls's central objection to classical utilitarianism was that, by extending to society the principle of rational choice appropriate for a single person, it "does not take seriously the distinction between persons" (*A Theory of Justice*, 1971, §5). John Taurek pressed the objection to its limit in "Should the Numbers Count?" (1977): each person's loss is a loss to that person, there is no impersonal sum of losses, and in a rescue he would rather toss a coin than save the greater number as such. Elethiomel's ledger of lives saved across the galaxy and the Culture's statistical warrant commit the Rawlsian error together. Both treat Darckense's death as an entry that other entries can offset.

Livueta's position is Taurekian. No number of strangers saved is commensurable with this loss, which was a loss to Darckense and to her. The novel's ethical claim is that the separateness of persons survives aggregation, and that in a civilization of aggregates it survives only as a refusal.

11.6 Irreversibility and the meaning of forgiveness

Arendt held that forgiveness exists to remedy the irreversibility of action. The Culture's technologies tend toward the abolition of irreversibility itself. Wounds heal, bodies regrow, lives lengthen; later in the sequence minds are backed up, and in *Surface Detail* soldiers are killed and resurrected in a virtual war. A civilization in which every injury can be undone is one in which nothing need be forgiven, and by the same token one in which nothing can be.

The chair is the residue of irreversibility in a civilization of reversal: the single injury Culture medicine cannot repair, because the person it destroyed cannot be restored. Livueta guards irreversibility against a civilization that would abolish it, and her refusal yields the novel's final philosophical claim: *a utopia must preserve the possibility of the unforgivable if it is to preserve the meaning of forgiveness*. A world without the irreparable is a world without moral weight. The Culture's own conduct confirms the point negatively, since it treats its instrument as indefinitely repairable. It can make him very nearly immortal; it cannot make him forgiven.

11.7 He can rearrange her name

The man resurfaces in *Surface Detail* as Vatueil, an anagram of Livueta. Read through the theorem, the alias is a last attempt at recursive conversion: the refusal itself disarticulated and reassembled into something wearable, a name to fight under. Yet the anagram also confesses the limit of conversion. He can rearrange the letters of her name; he cannot change her answer. The refusal is the one material in the novel that cannot be made into a chair. He can only carry it.

CONCLUSION

Sitting with the Bones

Use of Weapons *is a single argument conducted at three scales: wherever a power must act at a distance without appearing as the actor, it makes a person into a chair, and the chair's meaning arrives late, lands on someone else, and qualifies its maker to become one.*

The thesis has defended that claim in four movements. Part One showed that the novel's counter-chronology, born of Ken MacLeod's repair of an unworkable 1974 draft, is a *ballistic* form: an analytic tragedy yoked to a synthetic romance, whose two series cross like the lines of a gunsight inside the concentric rings Banks himself described. Part Two reconstructed the novel's philosophical inheritance. From Aristotle it takes the animate instrument and the dream of self-moving tools; from Kant, Weber and the Frankfurt School, the critique of persons used merely as means and of reason reduced to calculation; from Schmitt, Machiavelli, Sartre and Williams, the anatomy of the exception, the deniable agent and the dirty hand; from Locke, Reid, Parfit, Ricoeur, Kripke and Evans, the puzzles of identity and reference that a stolen name sets in motion; from Nietzsche and Freud, the economy of debt and the logic of afterwardsness; from Scarry and the myth of Atreus, the collapse of making into unmaking. Part Three set the novel among the fictions of benevolent power and showed how it transfers the tragic recognition from the hero to the reader. Part Four stated the Chairmaker's Theorem, derived the Aristotelian remainder and the moral crumple zone, and located in Livueta's refusal the one act that the economy of use cannot absorb.

Contributions

For the study of Banks, the thesis offers a unified reading in which the political critique of the Culture, the psychology of the protagonist and the novel's form are three projections of one structure, rather than three topics that happen to share a book. The reading also accommodates the novel's central interpretive crux, the question of

what the Culture's Minds knew. If they knew what the chair was, they hired the Chairmaker for the capacity it proved. If they did not, the concealment lemma applies to the Culture itself: its conscience remained usable only because the bones stayed hidden. Either way the theorem holds.

For philosophy, the thesis proposes six concepts derived from the novel and portable beyond it. The *Aristotelian remainder* names attributability as the residue that survives perfect automation. The *outsourcing of integrity* names the institutional answer to Williams's objection that a civilization can give by hiring someone else to be Jim. *Meaningful human blame* and *alignment laundering* name the retention of humans in automated systems for attribution rather than control, and the preservation of a system's apparent virtue by routing its costly acts through human proxies. The *equipoise contradiction* shows that a statistical warrant for intervention consumes itself the moment a control group is kept. *Chiastic ontology* names the two-way traffic across the boundary between persons and things. And the *unusable* names the ethical status of a refusal that serves no end, which in a civilization of reversible injuries becomes the guardian of moral weight.

For narrative theory, the thesis offers *ballistic narrative*, *displaced anagnorisis* and the *chiastic syuzhet* as descriptions of a form that later fiction, from *Time's Arrow* to *Memento*, has explored without naming. For criticism generally, it offers *osteopoetics*, the reading of made things for the concealed bodies on which they rest.

Further applications

Osteopoetics reaches well beyond Banks. Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) describes clones raised to give their organs until they "complete", whose childhood artworks are collected to test whether they have souls: persons converted into bodily resources, and making used as evidence of personhood, a chiastic structure in miniature. Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun* (2021) approaches the same boundary from the machine's side, following an artificial companion who is retired to a yard once her use is exhausted. Le Guin's Omelas, read osteopoetically, is a city whose radiance is the visible surface of a hidden body. And the institutional arrangements now being built around artificial intelligence, in which humans are retained in loops they cannot steer, are made things whose skeletons are still being assembled. The method asks of each the same three questions: which way the conversion runs, how long the meaning takes to arrive, and on whom the attribution falls.

Coda

Banks observed that the novel ends with someone throwing stones into a pond, the ripples spreading outward, and took the image as the emblem of its concentric design. The rings are the reading: forward strand and retrograde strand, frame and coda, the decades of interpretation that followed, and this thesis among them. Osteopoetics is the practice of following the rings back to the stone. What lies at the centre is a small white chair, and the reader who has followed the rings that far discovers that the question the novel leaves is not who Zakalwe is. It is what we have been sitting on.

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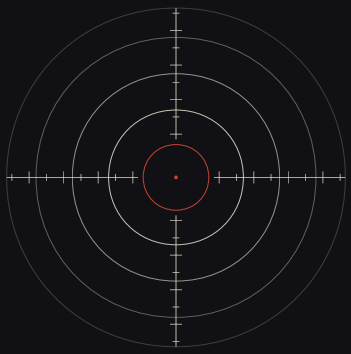
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Keywords

Terms coined in this thesis are marked in red.

Iain M. Banks | *Use of Weapons* | the Culture | Special Circumstances | space opera | science fiction studies | utopian studies | post-scarcity anarchism | humanitarian intervention | non-intervention | instrumentality | instrumental reason | weaponization | animate instrument | Aristotle | Kant | Formula of Humanity | *Toward Perpetual Peace* | Max Weber | monopoly of legitimate violence | Carl Schmitt | state of exception | dirty hands | integrity objection | Bernard Williams | moral luck | agent-regret | shame and guilt | Nietzsche | genealogy of guilt | Freud | *Nachträglichkeit* | afterwardsness | repetition compulsion | trauma theory | personal identity | Locke | Reid | Derek Parfit | ship of Theseus | narrative identity | Paul Ricoeur | rigid designation | Saul Kripke | Gareth Evans | prosopopoeia | Paul de Man | Levinas | Elaine Scarry | making and unmaking | Thyestean gift | Heidegger | equipment | Wittgenstein | meaning as use | forgiveness | the unforgivable | imprescriptibility | Hannah Arendt | Vladimir Jankélévitch | Jacques Derrida | Walter Benjamin | pure means | Giorgio Agamben | inoperativity | homo sacer | separateness of persons | irreversibility | retrograde narration | reverse chronology | analytic tragedy | anagnorisis | paralipsis | reader complicity | ballistic narrative | chiastic syuzhet | chiastic ontology | osteopoetics | Chairmaker's Theorem | Aristotelian remainder | outsourcing of integrity | equipoise contradiction | moral crumple zone | responsibility gap | meaningful human control | meaningful human blame | alignment laundering | AI ethics | superintelligence | Strugatsky brothers | Ursula K. Le Guin | Gene Wolfe | Stanisław Lem | Joseph Conrad | Jorge Luis Borges | Franz Kafka



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